

COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Medieval History 05 - The Tughlaqs

Muhammad bin Tughlaq and Firuz Shah compared through ambition, capacity, orthodoxy and durability

TOPIC-SPECIFIC COVER

Muhammad bin Tughlaq

- High ambition
- Second-capital logic
- Token currency
- Doab assessment
- Diwan-i-Kohi
- Khurasan / Qarachil
- Wider recruitment
- Caliphal rescript under pressure
- Innovation outruns compliance

Firuz Shah Tughlaq

- Reduced territorial horizon
- Elite conciliation
- Hereditary offices and iqta
- Canals and public works
- Diwan-i-Bandagan
- Charity and hospitals
- Separate jizya and sharper orthodoxy
- Succession softening after 1388

COMPARE, DON'T CARICATURE

Best lens

State capacity + source criticism

Key contrast

Innovation without compliance vs stability without central edge

Historical significance

Widest Delhi reach, Deccan consequences, canals, pre-Timur weakening

Schematic / not to scale where relevant. Source limits handled in surrounding text.

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

Medieval History 05 - The Tughlaqs: Muhammad bin Tughlaq & Firuz Shah - Complete Topic Package

Subject: Medieval Indian History | **Topic:** 05 | **Export date:** 2026-08-16 **Approval:** false - awaiting explicit user approval. **Source order:** repository Markdown -> local OCR-searchable Satish Chandra core and Part I Sultanate chapters -> local material-evidence excerpts on Ashokan pillars and Tughlaq architecture -> no forced live current-affairs claim -> Qdrant not used. **Tag rule:** [FACT] source-grounded statement; [ANALYSIS] evidence-led synthesis; [DEBATE] historiographical disagreement or conceptual caution; [LIMIT] evidentiary, chronological, geographical or source-genre qualification.

Package counts, provenance and honest limitations

- Learning sections: 24; learning MCQ loops: 16.
- Workbook content: 4 verified or honestly-adjacent PYQs; 40 original broad-coverage MCQs; 12 remedial MCQs; 6 original solved Mains questions; final register modules: 10.
- Original PNG visuals: 26 total - 25 body visuals plus 1 topic-specific cover visual. All maps and route diagrams are schematic and not to scale.
- Repository sources used most heavily: Topic 05 basic and advanced owners; bounded Topics 04, 06, 07, 08, 09 and 11; README.md; 00_Master-Chronology.md; REVISION-CHART_Ages-Eras-and-Distinctive-Features.md; local PYQ routing ledgers; validated question wording preserved in earlier repository packages.
- OCR evidence used most heavily from Satish Chandra's *History of Medieval India* chapters on Muhammad Tughlaq's experiments, Firuz and the decline of the Sultanate, and from *Medieval India: From Sultanat to the Mughals, Part I* chapters "Problems of a Centralised All-India-State" and "Reassertion of a State Based on Benevolence," plus the state and architecture chapters.
- Material-evidence support used where needed from the local Upinder Singh export on the later life of Ashokan pillars, especially the Topra and Meerut pillar transport accounts associated with Firuz Shah.
- [LIMIT] The Tughlaq archive is heavily mediated by elite Persian chronicles. Barani is indispensable but later, moralising, aristocratic and hostile to "low-born" advancement; Isami writes from displacement; Ibn Battuta writes as a traveller-court insider attracted to the dramatic; Firuz's *Futuhāt* is self-presentation rather than neutral audit.
- [LIMIT] Direct locally verified UPSC ownership is narrow: one routed 2021 Prelims question clearly touches Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq by name; a 2022 routed Prelims question tests Mongol chronology including Muhammad; the most useful Mains questions are adjacent source-and-technology questions rather than direct Tughlaq prompts.
- [LIMIT] No fabricated percentages, tax rates, troop strengths, slave totals, coin denominations, canal routes or attribution sequences are used here. When chroniclers provide numbers, they are marked as **reported** and kept separate from secure inference.
- [LIMIT] Topic 05 owns the Tughlaq transition, Muhammad's experiments, Firuz's benevolence/public works, source criticism around the two reigns, and the immediate structural road to post-1388 fragmentation. Topic 04 owns Khalji institutions and late Khalji collapse in depth; Topic 09 owns Vijayanagara-Bahmani development beyond the Delhi-overstretch frame; Topic 06 owns Timur, Sayyids and Lodis as the main narrative after Firuz.

Sources actually used

Source class	Exact source	Use and caveat
Repository knowledge	Topic 05 basic and advanced owners; bounded Topics 04, 06, 07, 08, 09 and 11; 00_Master-Chronology.md; REVISION-CHART_Ages-Eras-and-Distinctive-Features.md; Medieval README.md; PYQ routing ledgers and verified question wording preserved inside earlier packages.	Controlled chronology, owner boundaries, institutional vocabulary, architectural caution, source warnings and PYQ provenance.
Local book	Satish Chandra, <i>History of Medieval India</i> , searchable OCR around printed pp. 106-127 and related Sultanate economy/state pages.	Foundation for Muhammad's experiments, Daulatabad, token currency, doab crisis, Firuz's canals and the succession decline.
Local book	Satish Chandra, <i>Medieval India: From Sultanat to the Mughals, Part I</i> , searchable OCR around printed pp. 97-127, 135-146 and 232-235.	Deeper control for Ghiyasuddin's moderation, source criticism, Khurasan/Qarachil, Firuz's fiscal-benevolent model, state theory and Tughlaq architecture.
Material archive	Local Upinder Singh export on Ashokan pillars and their medieval afterlives.	Used narrowly for the Topra/Meerut pillar transport sequence and later inscriptional afterlife; not used to inflate broader Tughlaq political claims.
Named primary traditions through source-critical synthesis	Ziauddin Barani (<i>Tarikh-i Firuz Shahi</i> , <i>Fatawa-i Jahandari</i>), Isami, Ibn Battuta, Shams Siraj Afif, <i>Futuh-i Firuz Shahi</i> , coins, inscriptions, canals and surviving monuments.	Used with explicit genre caution: report, advice, travel narrative, ruler self-fashioning and material survival are separated from inference.
Live official or heritage source	None required for this export.	Repository Markdown and OCR-searchable books were sufficient; no decorative current-affairs hook was forced into a historical topic.

Original visual asset index

- notes/Medieval-Indian-History/assets/05_The-Tughlaqs-Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq-Firuz-Shah/00_tughlaq_comparative_cover.png
- notes/Medieval-Indian-History/assets/05_The-Tughlaqs-Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq-Firuz-Shah/01_tughlaq_chronology_evidence_spine.png
- notes/Medieval-Indian-History/assets/05_The-Tughlaqs-Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq-Firuz-Shah/02_ghiyas_transition_death_source_layers.png
- notes/Medieval-Indian-History/assets/05_The-Tughlaqs-Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq-Firuz-Shah/03_muhammad_empire_pressures_map.png
- notes/Medieval-Indian-History/assets/05_The-Tughlaqs-Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq-Firuz-Shah/04_five_experiments_overview.png
- notes/Medieval-Indian-History/assets/05_The-Tughlaqs-Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq-Firuz-Shah/05_delhi_daulatabad_phases_myths.png
- notes/Medieval-Indian-History/assets/05_The-Tughlaqs-Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq-Firuz-Shah/06_token_currency_trust_flow.png
- notes/Medieval-Indian-History/assets/05_The-Tughlaqs-Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq-Firuz-Shah/07_doab_tax_famine_rebellion_chain.png
- notes/Medieval-Indian-History/assets/05_The-Tughlaqs-Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq-Firuz-Shah/08_diwan_i_kohi_agricultural_model.png

- notes/Medieval-Indian-History/assets/05_The-Tughlaqs-Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq-Firuz-Shah/09_khurasan_qarachil_comparison.png
- notes/Medieval-Indian-History/assets/05_The-Tughlaqs-Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq-Firuz-Shah/10_rebellions_fragmentation_timeline.png
- notes/Medieval-Indian-History/assets/05_The-Tughlaqs-Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq-Firuz-Shah/11_muhammad_state_capacity_diagnostic.png
- notes/Medieval-Indian-History/assets/05_The-Tughlaqs-Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq-Firuz-Shah/12_source_matrix_barani_isami_ibn_battuta.png
- notes/Medieval-Indian-History/assets/05_The-Tughlaqs-Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq-Firuz-Shah/13_firuz_accession_political_bargain.png
- notes/Medieval-Indian-History/assets/05_The-Tughlaqs-Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq-Firuz-Shah/14_hereditary_iqta_offices_flow.png
- notes/Medieval-Indian-History/assets/05_The-Tughlaqs-Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq-Firuz-Shah/15_revenue_cess_irrigation_policy_matrix.png
- notes/Medieval-Indian-History/assets/05_The-Tughlaqs-Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq-Firuz-Shah/16_canal_public_works_network.png
- notes/Medieval-Indian-History/assets/05_The-Tughlaqs-Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq-Firuz-Shah/17_firuz_urban_architecture_matrix.png
- notes/Medieval-Indian-History/assets/05_The-Tughlaqs-Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq-Firuz-Shah/18_ashokan_pillar_transport_process.png
- notes/Medieval-Indian-History/assets/05_The-Tughlaqs-Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq-Firuz-Shah/19_diwan_i_bandagan_ecosystem.png
- notes/Medieval-Indian-History/assets/05_The-Tughlaqs-Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq-Firuz-Shah/20_welfare_departments_matrix.png
- notes/Medieval-Indian-History/assets/05_The-Tughlaqs-Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq-Firuz-Shah/21_conciliation_vs_orthodoxy_comparison.png
- notes/Medieval-Indian-History/assets/05_The-Tughlaqs-Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq-Firuz-Shah/22_muhammad_vs_firuz_structural_matrix.png
- notes/Medieval-Indian-History/assets/05_The-Tughlaqs-Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq-Firuz-Shah/23_succession_breakdown_causal_web.png
- notes/Medieval-Indian-History/assets/05_The-Tughlaqs-Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq-Firuz-Shah/24_historiography_comparison.png
- notes/Medieval-Indian-History/assets/05_The-Tughlaqs-Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq-Firuz-Shah/25_gs1_answer_spine.png

PART I - Complete learning session

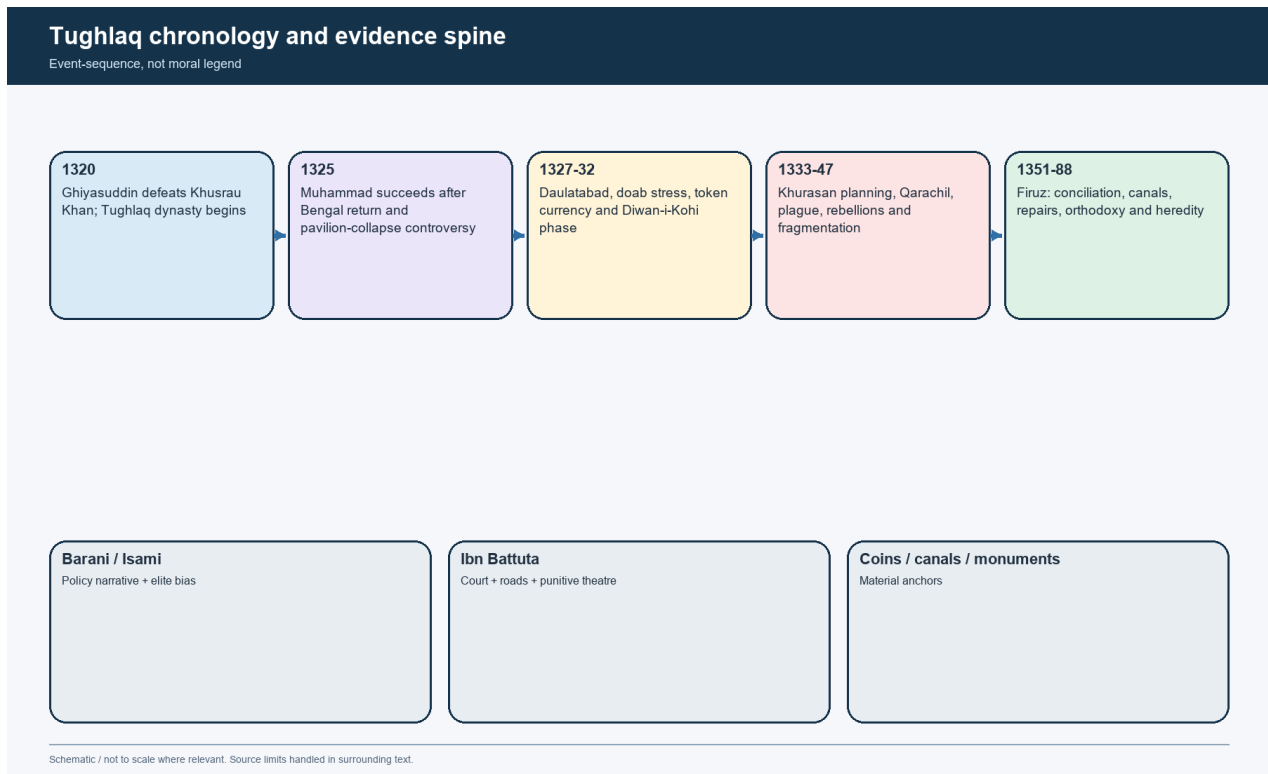
01. Scope, framing and chronology discipline

[FACT] Topic 05 owns the Tughlaq arc from **1320**, when Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq displaced Khusrau Khan, to **1388**, when Firuz Shah died and the succession order unravelled. It uses late Khalji collapse only as inherited context and treats Timur's invasion and the Sayyid-Lodi aftermath as the main subject of Topic 06.

[ANALYSIS] The strongest framing is **source criticism plus state-capacity comparison**. Muhammad bin Tughlaq should not be flattened into the schoolbook caricature of a "wise fool"; Firuz Shah should not be romanticised as a simply benevolent welfare ruler. The real contrast is between two different ways of holding together a very large Sultanate: one through high ambition, uniformity and risky innovation, the other through conciliation, heredity and developmental works.

[DEBATE] The source families themselves force caution. Barani moralises from an aristocratic angle; Isami remembers from displacement; Ibn Battuta records wonder, gifts, punishments and urban travel; Firuz's own *Futuhāt*

stages self-justification; coins, canals, forts and pillars show material claims but not the total lived experience of the empire.



01. Tughlaq chronology and evidence spine

Chronology visual. Rulers, experiments, rebellions and evidence families are separated so that event, reputation and later memory are never collapsed into one line of story.

Topic ownership firewall

Owner	What stays primarily there	What Topic 05 legitimately uses
Topic 04 - Khaljis	Alauddin's integrated military-fiscal system, Siri, market controls, Mongol pressure and the fall of the Khaljis	Only the immediate handoff into the Ghiyasuddin takeover and a few institutional comparison points
Topic 06 - Decline / Timur / Sayyids / Lodis	Timur's invasion, the Sayyids, Lodis and fifteenth-century north-Indian balance of power	Only the post-1388 causal bridge showing why Delhi weakened before Timur
Topic 07 - Sultanate administration, economy and society	General offices, revenue structure, town life, trade and social groups in long duration	Only Tughlaq-specific reversals, experiments and capacity stress
Topic 09 - Vijayanagara and Bahmani	Full Deccan state formation after Delhi's overstretch	Only the Delhi-side conditions that allowed southern breakaways
Topic 11 - Art, architecture and culture	Full Sultanate architectural and cultural survey	Only bounded political meaning of Tughlaqabad, Kotla Firoz Shah, Hauz Khas repairs and pillar transport

Governing thesis

- [ANALYSIS] Muhammad bin Tughlaq expanded direct rule and tried to standardise the empire faster than the available instruments of information, trust and enforcement could sustain.
- [ANALYSIS] Firuz Shah reduced punitive intensity, invested in canals and urban works, and stabilised the elite through heredity - but this traded short-term order for long-term central weakening.
- [LIMIT] Neither ruler can be judged only by intention or only by outcome. For UPSC, the mark-winning move is to distinguish **objective**, **administrative instrument**, **social cost** and **durability**.

02. From Khalji collapse to Tughlaq legitimacy: Ghiyasuddin, Tughlaqabad and the death controversy

[FACT] Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq, the former frontier commander and warden of the marches, led a coalition of officers against Khusrau Khan in **1320**. In a hard-fought battle outside Delhi, Khusrau was defeated and killed, ending the late Khalji crisis.

[FACT] Ghiyasuddin's brief reign was devoted to restoration and consolidation. The advanced OCR explicitly praises his policy of **moderation**: taxation should not ruin the countryside, agriculture and crafts should expand, and the people should neither become so rich as to rebel nor so poor as to cease cultivation.

[FACT] He restored some neglected noble families to office, audited extraordinary gifts of the previous regime, reduced some long-held revenue-free grants, sent Ulugh Khan (the future Muhammad bin Tughlaq) to restore the imperial position in Warangal, and personally marched to Bengal, where the campaign succeeded.

[FACT] The palace-fortress complex of **Tughlaqabad**, together with Ghiyasuddin's elevated domed tomb, proclaimed a new dynastic style: fortified austerity, sloping battered walls and a preference for strength over ornament.

[LIMIT] Ghiyasuddin's death in **1325** must be handled through source layers. A pavilion erected by Ulugh Khan to welcome him after the Bengal campaign collapsed during the parade of captured elephants. Contemporary suspicion, later conspiracy stories and the Nizamuddin-Auliya curse legend all survive; the advanced OCR, however, states that modern research does **not** support the idea of a deliberate murderous conspiracy.

Ghiyasuddin: transition, Tughlaqabad and death source layers

Separate secure event from later legend

1320-1325

Secure political line

1320 victory over Khusrau Khan
Moderation and agrarian concern
Warangal and Bengal assertion
Tughlaqabad and tomb as dynastic statement

Layered death narratives

Pavilion collapse after Bengal return = secure
Conspiracy suspicion = later inference
Nizamuddin curse = legendary memory
Modern secure answer = uncertainty, not certainty

Owner boundary

Topic 04 gives late Khalji breakdown in depth

Exam line

Ghiyasuddin is a hinge ruler, not a footnote

Schematic / not to scale where relevant. Source limits handled in surrounding text.

02. Ghiyasuddin transition, Tughlaqabad and death source layers

Transition visual. Secure political sequence, dynastic architecture and the death controversy are separated into evidence, report and legend.

Secure event versus layered interpretation

Dimension	Secure minimum statement	Why caution is necessary
Rise to power	Ghiyasuddin defeated Khusrau Khan in 1320 and founded the Tughlaq dynasty	The moral language of chroniclers should not be mistaken for complete political sociology
Policy	Moderation, agrarian concern, restoration of order and renewed southern/eastern assertion	The reign was too brief to convert every intention into stable institution
Bengal campaign	Successful enough for the ruler to return in triumph	The campaign is often remembered only as the prelude to his death
Death	Pavilion collapse while welcoming the Sultan after Bengal	Conspiracy certainty, saintly curse and elephant accident belong to different source layers

Why Ghiyasuddin matters here

- [ANALYSIS] Topic 05 should not begin with Muhammad as though he inherited a blank slate. He inherited Ghiyasuddin's partially restored authority, direct-ruled Deccan ambitions and a fresh dynastic legitimacy still being built.
- [ANALYSIS] The sharpest contrast is not Ghiyasuddin versus Firuz but Ghiyasuddin's **moderated restoration** versus Muhammad's **high-speed uniformity project**.

03. Muhammad bin Tughlaq's accession, intellectual profile and the pressures of scale

[FACT] Muhammad bin Tughlaq came to power in 1325 with an unusual intellectual profile for a medieval ruler. The local OCR describes him as deeply read in religion, philosophy, mathematics and medicine, interested in Persian and Hindi poetry, and willing to converse not only with Muslim mystics but also with Hindu yogis and Jain saints such as **Jinaprabha Suri**.

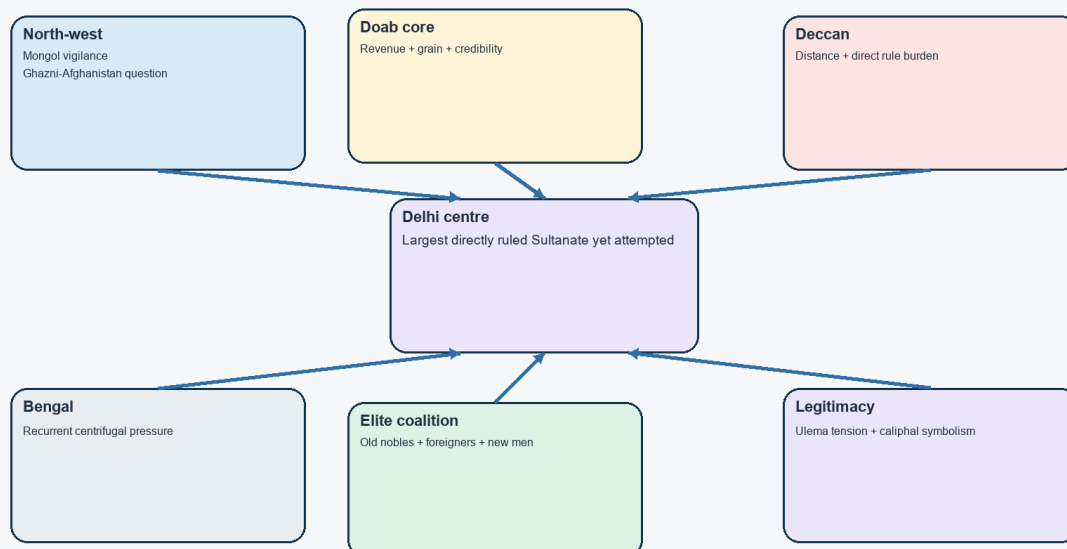
[FACT] Barani's charge that Muhammad was a "rationalist" is valuable evidence, not merely abuse. It shows that the Sultan would not accept many claims merely on inherited religious authority and that his relationship with orthodox theologians was tense from the start.

[FACT] He also inherited the widest directly ruled Delhi Sultanate yet attempted: the old north-Indian core, Gujarat, Malwa, the Deccan, Warangal and the farther southern belt up to the Madurai horizon. This was an empire of long roads, delayed communication, high military transport costs and regionally varied loyalties.

[ANALYSIS] The experiments of the reign become intelligible only when we place them under the pressure of **scale**. The problem was not simply "a ruler with strange ideas"; it was a ruler trying to make distant annexations administratively legible and fiscally usable.

Muhammad bin Tughlaq's empire pressures map

Schematic pressure-zones, not exact borders



Schematic / not to scale where relevant. Source limits handled in surrounding text.

03. Muhammad bin Tughlaq's empire pressures map

Schematic pressure map. It is not a territorial border map; it shows the problem-zones that shaped Muhammad's decisions.

Pressure grid

Pressure zone	Core problem	Why it mattered to Muhammad
North-west frontier	Mongol threat, Ghazni-Afghanistan question, Punjab vigilance	A purely defensive frontier left Delhi reactive
Doab and Delhi provisioning belt	Grain, revenue, transport and price credibility	Delhi's army and court could not function without a dependable agrarian core
Deccan and far south	Distance, tribute enforcement, direct-rule burden and local resentment	Annexation without local administrative depth became fragile
Elite coalition	Old nobles, foreigners, Indian converts and "new men"	Recruitment widened talent but weakened cohesion
Legitimacy and religious authority	Conflict with ulema, saintly networks and symbolic caliphal idiom	Every controversial policy also had a reputational cost

Safe interpretive line

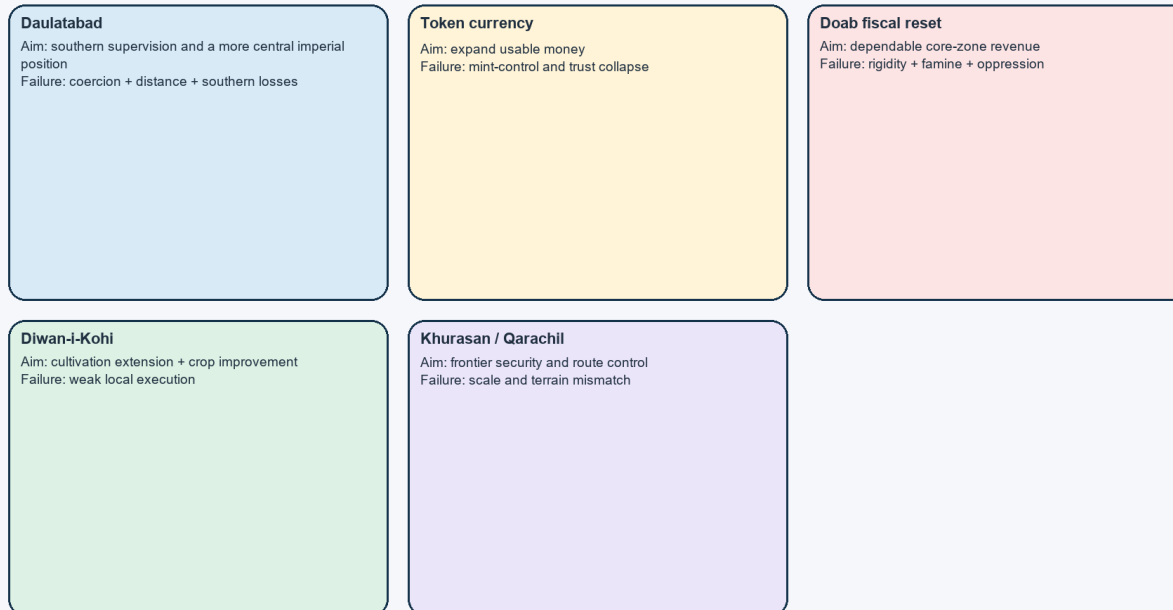
- [ANALYSIS] Muhammad's reign was a test of whether the Delhi Sultanate could move from a conquest-plus-tribute order to a more **uniformly supervised all-India state**. The answer was mixed: imagination outran coordination.

04. The five experiment-clusters: aim, instrument and failure mode

[ANALYSIS] Chroniclers remembered Muhammad bin Tughlaq through "experiments" because they were visible moments when intention, instrument and administrative reality collided. The exam-safe move is not to rehearse a failure-list but to ask what each measure was trying to solve, what instrument it required, and where that instrument broke.

Five experiment-clusters under Muhammad bin Tughlaq

Aim - Instrument - failure mode



Schematic / not to scale where relevant. Source limits handled in surrounding text.

04. Five major experiment-clusters overview

Overview visual. The experiments are grouped by administrative problem, not by legend.

Experiment cluster	Immediate objective	Administrative instrument required	Principal failure mode
Daulatabad second capital	Better southern supervision and more central imperial positioning	Managed migration, communication, local buy-in, dual-capital logistics	Distance, coercive pressure, southern losses and homesickness
Token currency	Expand usable money and fiscal flexibility without dependence on silver supply	Mint control, verification, counter-forgery regime, public trust	Weak monopoly over coin authentication and widespread imitation
Doab fiscal reset	Raise dependable state demand from the core agrarian zone	Fair assessment, locally monitored collection, famine resilience	Standard-yield rigidity, official oppression and climatic stress
Diwan-i-Amir-i-Kohi	Extend cultivation and improve crop quality	Honest local officials, credit discipline, agronomic knowledge	Corruption, weak supervision and over-optimistic scale
Frontier military projects	Push defence outward and secure the north-west / Himalayas	Sustained logistics, reliable intelligence, terrain knowledge, finance	Strategic overreach and poor environmental fit

Two big cautions

- [LIMIT] "Bold experiment" does **not** mean "modern policy laboratory." These were coercive medieval state measures operating through grain extraction, iqta assignments, military command and court authority.
- [LIMIT] Failure did **not** erase significance. Several ideas - agricultural loans, developmental cultivation, second-capital logic, fiscal-monetary experimentation - had a long afterlife even when the immediate version failed.

05. Daulatabad: second capital, selective migration and the myth of a totally emptied Delhi

[FACT] Devagiri/Deogir was already central to Delhi's southern strategy before Muhammad's accession. Alauddin had raided it, later Delhi had used it as a base, and Muhammad himself had spent significant time there as prince and military commander. Renaming it **Daulatabad** was therefore politically meaningful, not whimsical.

[FACT] The advanced OCR is explicit that **no mass exodus of the whole population of Delhi** was ordered. Pressure fell mainly on officers, their followers, nobles, leading men, Sufis, ulema and grandees. Delhi remained inhabited, and coins continued to be struck there while the Sultan was at Daulatabad.

[FACT] Preparations were serious: the road was organised with halting stations and facilities, the city was divided into wards (*mohallas*), and grants, houses and boarding arrangements were made for migrants. These details matter because they show that the move was planned, not impulsively improvised.

[ANALYSIS] The motive most safely attributed to Muhammad is the desire for a **second capital** better placed for southern oversight and more central to the enlarged empire. Popular textbook language about a "capital transfer" becomes misleading if it implies permanent abandonment of Delhi.

[LIMIT] The journey was still punishing. It was long, undertaken in severe heat, and accompanied by coercive inspection of houses and substantial discontent. Once the southern direct-rule project faltered in the mid-1330s, the political logic of Daulatabad weakened, and people were allowed to return.

[ANALYSIS] The long-term consequence was real even though the policy failed. Roads improved, north-south contact intensified, and many migrants - especially learned and religious figures - stayed back, helping Daulatabad become a Deccan centre of Islamic learning later useful to the Bahmani world.

Delhi-Daulatabad phases and myth-corrections

Second-capital logic, selective pressure, long afterlife



Myth rejected
Delhi was not totally emptied

Safe phrase
Daulatabad as second capital

Schematic / not to scale where relevant. Source limits handled in surrounding text.

05. Delhi-Daulatabad transfer phases and myth-corrections

Phases visual. Planning, pressure, migration, return and long-run cultural consequences are separated from exaggerated myth.

Myth-correction table

Common simplification	Secure correction
Muhammad shifted the entire population of Delhi	The pressure was severe, but it chiefly targeted officers, grandees, Sufis, ulema and associated groups
Delhi ceased to function	Delhi remained inhabited and continued mint activity
Daulatabad was chosen randomly	It was already a strategic Deccan base and more central to the enlarged empire
The move had no long-term effect	It intensified north-south communication and helped seed Deccan Islamic learning

06. Token currency: monetary imagination, credibility failure and the counterfeit problem

[FACT] Muhammad bin Tughlaq issued **copper and brass** coins intended to circulate at the value of the silver *tanka*. This was a token-currency experiment, but it must not be falsely described as "paper currency."

[FACT] The idea itself was not unprecedented in the wider world. The local OCR explicitly refers to Chinese paper currency under Qublai Khan and to earlier Iranian experimentation. The experiment is therefore better interpreted as a problem of **state credibility and enforcement**, not of civilisational ignorance.

[DEBATE] Barani links the move to military ambition and treasury pressure; modern inference can also connect it to a wider silver shortage and the desire to enlarge monetary circulation. But motive should be stated cautiously because Barani also contradicts himself on whether the treasury had already been drained.

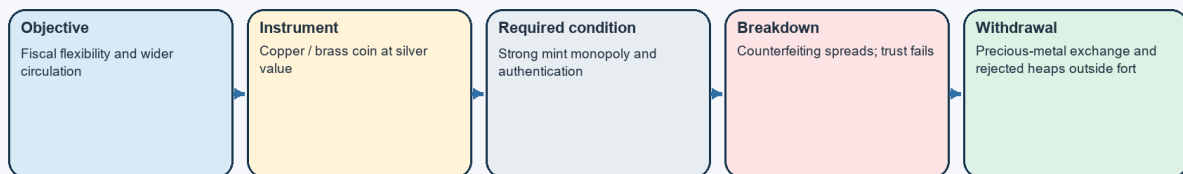
[FACT] The decisive failure lay in the inability of the state to **control imitation and authenticate issue**. Barani's famous line that every Hindu house became a mint is rhetorical, but it securely conveys the point that unofficial fabrication spread widely enough to destroy trust.

[FACT] Muhammad eventually withdrew the experiment and agreed to exchange precious metal for acceptable token pieces. Rejected forgeries accumulated in heaps outside the fort. Surviving specimens prove issue and design; they do not prove uniform success in circulation.

[ANALYSIS] The best verdict is not "an absurd idea," but "a financially and conceptually intelligible idea without the institutional monopoly required to make token value credible."

Token currency: mechanism, trust and collapse

The key question is credibility, not novelty alone



Trap

Not paper currency

Wider context

Chinese and Iranian precedents existed

Schematic / not to scale where relevant. Source limits handled in surrounding text.

06. Token currency mechanism: trust, counterfeit and collapse

Monetary-flow visual. The real fault line was credibility, not mere novelty.

Evidence and caution table

Claim	Support in local sources	Necessary caution
Copper and brass pieces were issued at silver value	Clear in concise and advanced OCR	Do not add unsupported denominations or numerical ratios
Wider precedents existed	China and Iranian references appear in OCR	A precedent elsewhere did not automatically solve Indian enforcement problems
Forgery ruined confidence	Central claim in Barani-derived narrative	The dramatic phrasing is rhetorical; the institutional lesson is the key point
Withdrawal required redemption in precious metal	Clear in the narrative	Do not assume every forged coin was accepted; rejected pieces remained outside the fort

07. The doab taxation crisis: standard yield, famine and rebellion

[FACT] Early in Muhammad's reign, the Gangetic doab saw a serious agrarian crisis and rebellion. The crucial point in the advanced OCR is that the problem was not simply "higher taxes" in the abstract. The assessment used **standard yield** rather than actual produce, and official prices rather than actual market prices when converting the state's share into cash.

[FACT] The old cesses - notably **ghari** (house tax) and **charai** (grazing tax) - were rigorously collected, cattle were branded and houses counted. The share demanded may still have been notionally half, but the *effective* burden under famine and oppressive collection could rise sharply.

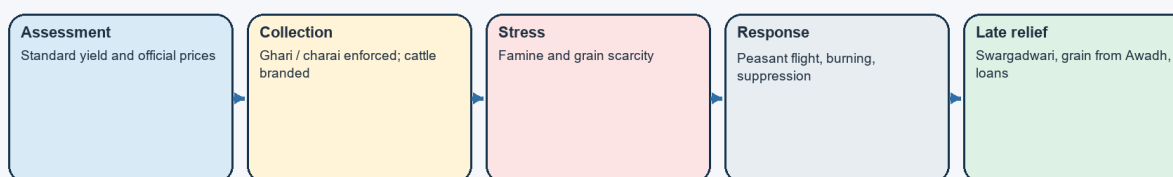
[FACT] Barani reports that peasants burnt grain-heaps, drove away cattle and abandoned cultivation, and that the area from Kannauj to Dalmu was devastated by suppression. Even if the rhetoric is exaggerated, the reality of a major doab agrarian upheaval is difficult to deny.

[FACT] Climatic failure worsened everything. The advanced OCR explicitly notes famine, rising grain prices, relief camps at Delhi, grain brought from Awadh and Muhammad's move to **Swargadwari** because the atmosphere of Delhi had become pestilential.

[ANALYSIS] The best comparison with Alauddin is subtle. Alauddin had also demanded heavily, yet Muhammad faced sharper rebellion because the combination of standard-yield rigidity, local official excess and environmental stress proved politically explosive.

Doab tax-famine-rebellion causal chain

Policy interacted with ecology



Schematic / not to scale where relevant. Source limits handled in surrounding text.

07. Doab tax-famine-rebellion causal chain

Causal-chain visual. Policy, official behaviour and climate interacted; none alone fully explains the crisis.

Chronology caution

Stage	Secure content	Why not overstate
Assessment reset	Standard yield and official prices sharpened burden	Exact percentage escalation is not securely recoverable from rhetoric alone
Agrarian distress	Peasant flight, destruction and suppression in the doab	Spread beyond the doab is less securely supported
Famine	Grain scarcity, high prices, relief measures, move to Swargadwari	Climatic failure complicates pure "bad policy" explanations
Historical lesson	Core-zone extraction without flexible information destroys credibility	Avoid treating the crisis as proof that the entire empire became ungovernable at once

08. Diwan-i-Amir-i-Kohi: state loans, cultivation extension and the limits of agrarian engineering

[FACT] After the doab famine phase, Muhammad bin Tughlaq tried to reverse direction and promote agrarian development. A special department called the **Diwan-i-Amir-i-Kohi** was created to supervise a tract of about **30 kroh by 30 kroh**.

[FACT] The objective had two parts: bring more land under cultivation and improve crop quality. Barani's own phrasing, preserved in the advanced OCR, imagines a graded shift from barley to wheat, from wheat to sugarcane, and then to higher-value crops such as grapes and dates.

[FACT] Around **100 shiqdars** were appointed, given honour, horses and large sums for agricultural loans (*sondhar*). Reported figures such as seventy lakh tankas or even two crores in later recollection must be handled as reported, not audited certainty.

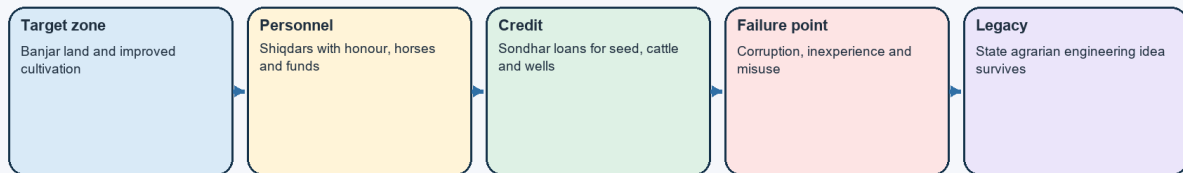
[LIMIT] The advanced OCR argues that the scheme aimed to bring **banjar** or barren land under cultivation, not genuinely uncultivable *usar* land, despite Barani's sharper wording. This distinction matters because it changes the policy from impossible fantasy to risky agricultural extension.

[FACT] The scheme failed because the chosen personnel were inexperienced, corrupt or both. Money intended as loans was consumed for personal use, the new land was not adequately brought under cultivation, and recovery collapsed.

[ANALYSIS] Yet the historical significance is large. State-supported agricultural loans and planned cultivation improvement survived the immediate failure and reappeared later under Firuz and more systematically under the Mughals.

Diwan-i-Amir-i-Kohi agricultural-extension model

Credit, supervision, crop improvement and weak execution



Schematic / not to scale where relevant. Source limits handled in surrounding text.

08. Diwan-i-Kohi agricultural-extension model

Agricultural-extension visual. It separates objective, instrument, failure point and long-run policy legacy.

Safe verdict

- [ANALYSIS] Diwan-i-Kohi was **not** proof of modern developmental bureaucracy, but it was more than absurd overreach. It shows a state thinking in terms of credit, crop improvement and revenue through agrarian expansion.
- [LIMIT] Scale claims belong to reported narrative, not precise administrative statistics.

09. The Khurasan project and the Qarachil expedition: do not conflate them

[FACT] The **Khurasan project** arose from north-western strategic anxiety. After the Tarmashirin episode and the fluid politics of Transoxiana, Iran, Ghazni and Afghanistan, Muhammad bin Tughlaq considered a forward move that could secure the frontier more aggressively. The advanced OCR suggests that even a limited aim - Kabul/Ghazni/Afghanistan - is more defensible than fantasies of global conquest.

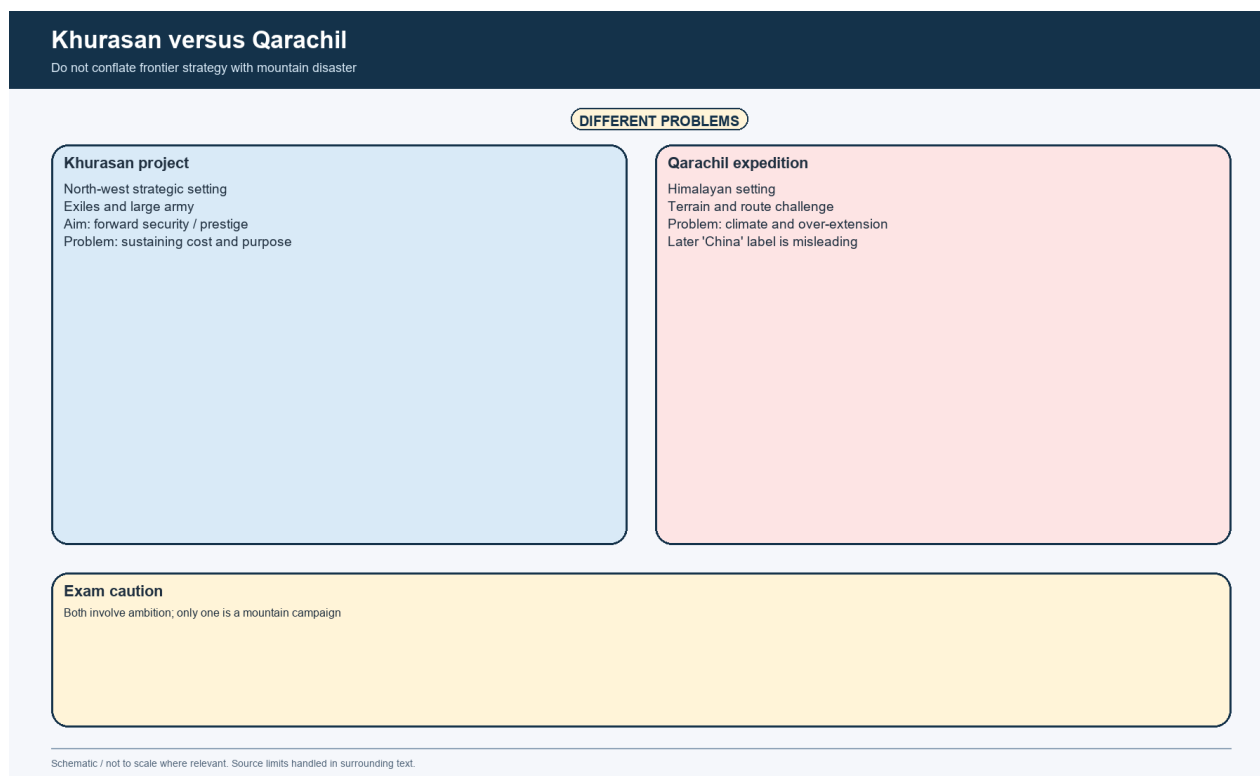
[FACT] To support this, he reportedly entertained exiles and grandees from those regions and raised a very large army, commonly given in the sources as **370,000**. The scale must be labelled as **reported**.

[LIMIT] Barani's wording sometimes expands the aim to Khurasan, Iraq and even beyond. The safer conclusion is that the project aimed at an outward strategic frontier and prestige offensive, not necessarily at a coherent transcontinental conquest plan.

[FACT] The **Qarachil** expedition, by contrast, was a Himalayan campaign. The advanced OCR places it in the Kulu-Kangra / Kumaon-Kashmir horizon and explicitly rejects the later claim that it was an expedition to conquer China.

[FACT] The Qarachil force suffered disastrous environmental defeat after moving too far into inhospitable terrain. The famous line that only **10 of 10,000** returned is again a reported chronicler figure. Yet the same source tradition says a local ruler later accepted Delhi's overlordship.

[ANALYSIS] Put differently: Khurasan was a frontier-strategy problem; Qarachil was a terrain-and-logistics problem. Joining them into a single tale of irrationality destroys the history.



09. Khurasan project versus Qarachil expedition

Comparison visual. Objective, geography, preparation and result differ sharply between the two enterprises.

Comparison table

Dimension	Khurasan project	Qarachil expedition
Strategic setting	Central Asian / Afghan frontier politics	Himalayan mountain corridor
Aim	Forward security / possible reassertion toward Ghazni-Afghanistan and beyond	Control of a hill region and/or route-security objective
Instrument	Large army recruitment and political invitations to exiles	Field expedition in difficult terrain
Principal problem	Sustaining cost and purpose	Terrain, climate and over-extension
Exam trap	"World conquest madness"	"China campaign"

10. Rebellions, plague and regional fragmentation: Deccan, Bengal, Gujarat, Sindh and the limits of direct rule

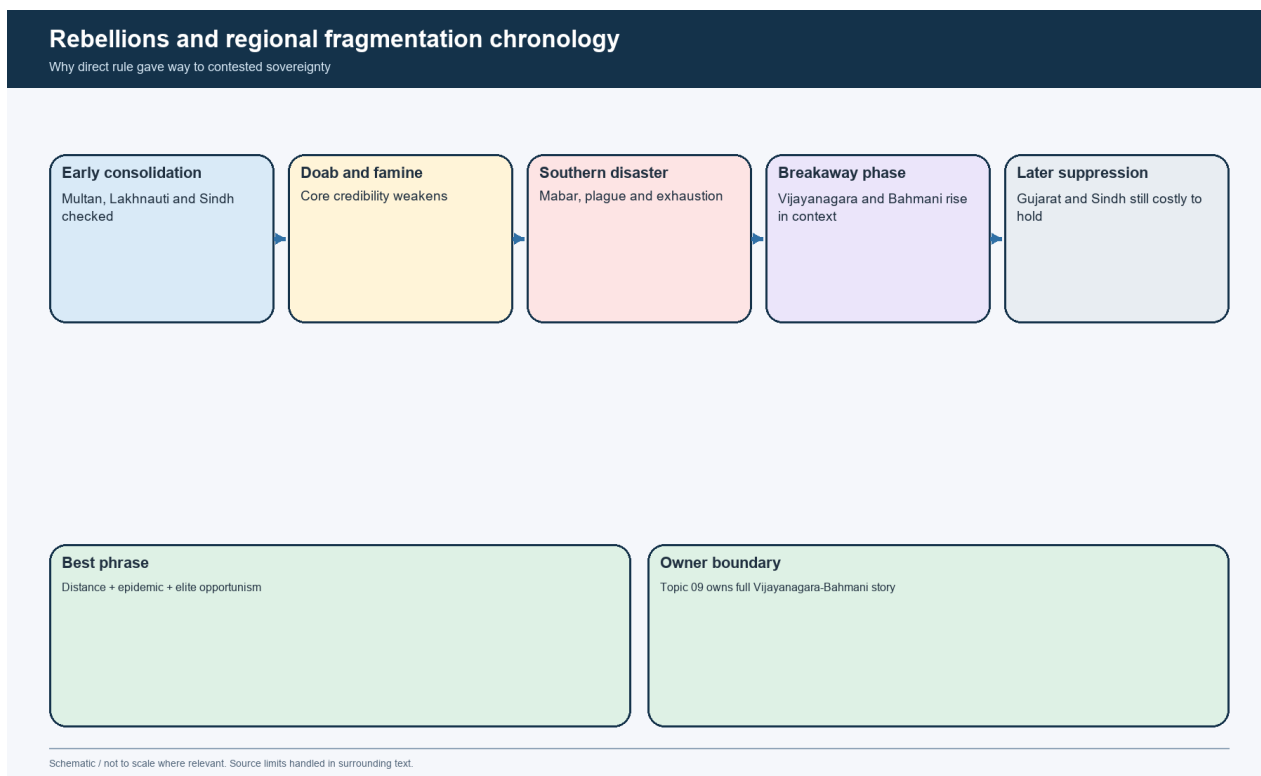
[FACT] The advanced OCR usefully divides Muhammad's reign into phases. The first decade after accession was largely about consolidation, with rebellions in places like Multan, Lakhnauti and Sindh checked. The second decade became much more difficult as famine, southern revolts and epidemic weakened the state's striking power.

[FACT] The rebellions came in sequence across **Bengal, Mabar, Warangal, Kampili, Awadh, Gujarat and Sindh**. Muhammad repeatedly moved personally from one theatre to another, wearing down his army and limiting the formation of stable delegated trust.

[FACT] The southern turning point was disastrous. The Mabar campaign coincided with plague in the army; the concise OCR says two-thirds of the army perished. Shortly afterwards, **Harihara and Bukka** established the principality that grew into Vijayanagara, while foreign nobles near Daulatabad launched the Bahmani state.

[ANALYSIS] Topic 05 uses Vijayanagara and Bahmani only as signs of Delhi's overreach and broken southern control. Their own institutions, politics and cultural worlds belong primarily to Topic 09.

[FACT] Bengal also became independent again, while Gujarat and Sindh required severe effort. Muhammad was still strong enough to suppress some western and central rebellions, which is why his total unpopularity should not be exaggerated.



10. Rebellions and regional fragmentation chronology

Fragmentation timeline. It distinguishes direct revolt, military overstretch, epidemic shock and the rise of successor states.

Region-by-region language

Region	What Topic 05 should say safely
Bengal	Recurrent centrifugal zone; independence regained; Delhi could not hold it durably
Deccan / Daulatabad	Direct-rule burden, noble rebellion and southern communications crisis
Vijayanagara	Emerged in the context of Delhi's southern overstretch; full treatment belongs elsewhere
Bahmani	Grew from Deccan breakaway near Daulatabad; full state development belongs elsewhere
Gujarat and Sindh	Rebellion suppressed with great effort, revealing Delhi's continuing but costly reach

Best synthesis

- [ANALYSIS] Muhammad's empire did not collapse because one policy failed; it fragmented because **distance + fiscal pressure + elite opportunism + epidemic + repeated campaigning** outpaced the centre's ability to restore credible control.

11. Administration, the ruling class and Muhammad's state-capacity problem

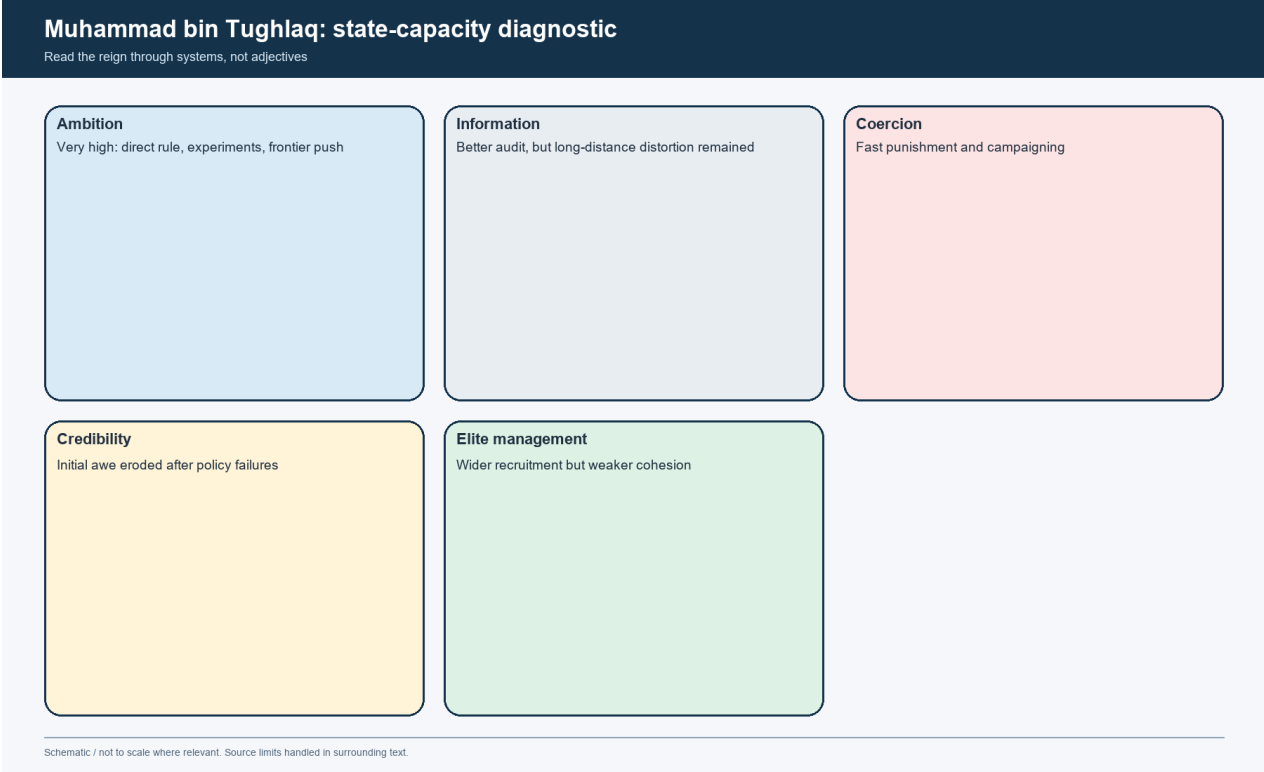
[FACT] Muhammad bin Tughlaq pushed administrative centralisation further than his predecessors. When provinces were annexed, revenue officials followed; according to Barani, the accounts of distant provinces were audited in the wazir's office in the same detailed fashion as villages in the doab.

[FACT] He also widened elite recruitment. The concise OCR states that he appointed people who did not belong to old noble families, including men from occupational backgrounds such as barbers, cooks, weavers and wine-makers, alongside foreigners and a few Hindus. Barani's fury at such appointments tells us as much about aristocratic

prejudice as about the appointments themselves.

[ANALYSIS] The recruitment of "new men" was not random social chaos. It was a way of reducing dependence on closed old-noble circles and of staffing a larger empire through talent and loyalty outside inherited aristocratic networks.

[LIMIT] The political cost was high. The nobility now contained foreigners, Indian converts, older elite families and court favourites without a single cohesive identity. Such a coalition could staff a wide empire, but it was also prone to fracture.



11. Muhammad's state-capacity diagnostic

Diagnostic visual. It reads the reign through ambition, information, credibility, coercion and geographic stretch rather than through personality labels alone.

Capacity diagnosis

Dimension	Strength under Muhammad	Limiting problem
Ambition	Very high - uniform rule, direct annexation, frontier push, agrarian engineering	Goals multiplied faster than institution-building
Information	Improved through audit, officials and court intelligence	Distant provinces still generated severe delay and distortion
Coercion	Strong capacity for punishment and rapid campaigning	Excess coercion damaged trust and encouraged rebellion
Credibility	High at first - Ibn Battuta still saw the Delhi ruler as one of the great rulers of the world	Daulatabad, token currency and doab crisis weakened faith in command
Elite management	Wider recruitment opened talent	Cohesion and inherited legitimacy became fragile

One-line UPSC takeaway

- [ANALYSIS] Muhammad's reign is the Sultanate's clearest demonstration that **administrative imagination without durable compliance mechanisms becomes self-defeating**.

12. Barani, Isami, Ibn Battuta and material evidence: how to read the Tughlaq archive

[FACT] The Tughlaq period cannot be taught safely through a single chronicler. Barani, Isami, Ibn Battuta, Afif, *Futuhāt-i Firuz Shahī*, coins and buildings each record a different slice of reality.

[FACT] **Barani** is indispensable for Muhammad's experiments and elite ideology, but he wrote later, moralises strongly, uses rhetorical scaling and deeply resents low-born advancement. He is crucial and dangerous at the same time.

[FACT] **Isami** is near-contemporary and especially valuable when Delhi-Deccan relations are at stake, but he writes from displacement and retrospective memory. He is not a neutral field report.

[FACT] **Ibn Battuta**, from Tangier, lived for years at Muhammad's court, held judicial office and travelled widely. He is especially useful for court ceremony, gifts, punishments, roads, products, urban scale and the atmosphere of power. The concise OCR also notes that he was more interested in the court than in the lives of ordinary people.

[FACT] **Material evidence** checks literary claims. Delhi mint continuity, Tughlaqabad, Ghiyasuddin's tomb, Kotla Firoz Shah, repaired monuments, canals and Ashokan-pillar movement all confirm activity; none by itself proves uniform administrative success.

Source matrix: Barani, Isami, Ibn Battuta and material evidence

Each source family answers a different question

Barani Policy sequence Elite ideology Rhetorical and anti-low-born bias	Isami Deccan displacement lens Useful alternative memory	Ibn Battuta Court, roads, gifts, punishments, products
Afif / Futuhat Firuz's later memory and self-presentation	Material evidence Coins, forts, canals, pillars, repairs	Method Prefer the minimum secure statement across sources

Schematic / not to scale where relevant. Source limits handled in surrounding text.

12. Ibn Battuta, Barani, Isami and material evidence comparison

Source-matrix visual. Use it to separate report, witness, moral judgement and physical trace.

Source-criticism matrix

Source	Best use	Main bias or limit	Safe classroom use
Barani	Policy sequence, elite ideology, doab, Daulatabad, token currency	Later, didactic, anti-low-born, rhetorical	Use as report + political mentality; do not quote every number or speech literally
Isami	Alternative lens on Deccan and Delhi overreach	Retrospective, displacement memory	Use to cross-check tone and consequence, not as raw field log
Ibn Battuta	Court, gift-punishment theatre, roads, city life, products	Traveller genre, wonder orientation, court-centred	Best for atmosphere and practice, not for total empire statistics
Afif / Futuhat	Firuz's later memory, benevolence claims, public works	Late court framing and ruler self-justification	Use with explicit claim-versus-implementation distinction
Coins / buildings / canals	Durable physical action and patronage	Selective survival; material claim != full control	Anchor literary claims in the material record

Method rule

- [ANALYSIS] When sources disagree, prefer the **minimum secure statement** that survives across more than one evidence family. This is the correct answer to both textbook caricature and ideological over-reading.

13. Muhammad bin Tughlaq and religion: ulema, caliphal legitimacy, Sufis and justice

[FACT] Muhammad bin Tughlaq was personally observant in prayers and fasting, yet the advanced OCR also presents him as a ruler who would not accept many things merely on faith. He associated with yogis and Jain saints, respected major Sufi tombs and is said to have connected himself at times with Hindu festivals such as Holi.

[FACT] This openness helped trigger hostility from sections of the orthodox. The advanced OCR reports that, because of his association with yogis and related practices, qazis issued a *fatwa* making rebellion against the Sultan legally possible.

[FACT] To answer this, Muhammad sought symbolic **caliphal legitimisation** from the Cairo-based Abbasid line. The local OCR says he first substituted the Caliph's name on coins and later received a formal *manshur* or rescript. The gesture did not fundamentally improve his standing with orthodox opponents.

[ANALYSIS] The best line is to reject modern shorthand from both sides. Muhammad was neither a secular-liberal moderniser nor a simple anti-religious tyrant. He was a Muslim ruler of strong reason-of-state instincts, willing to supplement *shara* with *zawabit*, open to multiple intellectual worlds, and also capable of extreme punitive violence.

[LIMIT] Brutality is part of the record. Chroniclers and Ibn Battuta alike emphasise his capacity for lavish rewards and drastic punishments. A balanced answer therefore links intellectual range with coercive intensity instead of substituting one for the other.

Safe verdict

- [ANALYSIS] Muhammad's religious politics were about **contested authority**, not about a neat binary between belief and unbelief. He broadened the court's intellectual contact-zone while failing to persuade orthodox intermediaries that his style of rule was legitimate.

14. Firuz Shah's accession after the Sindh crisis: conciliation as statecraft

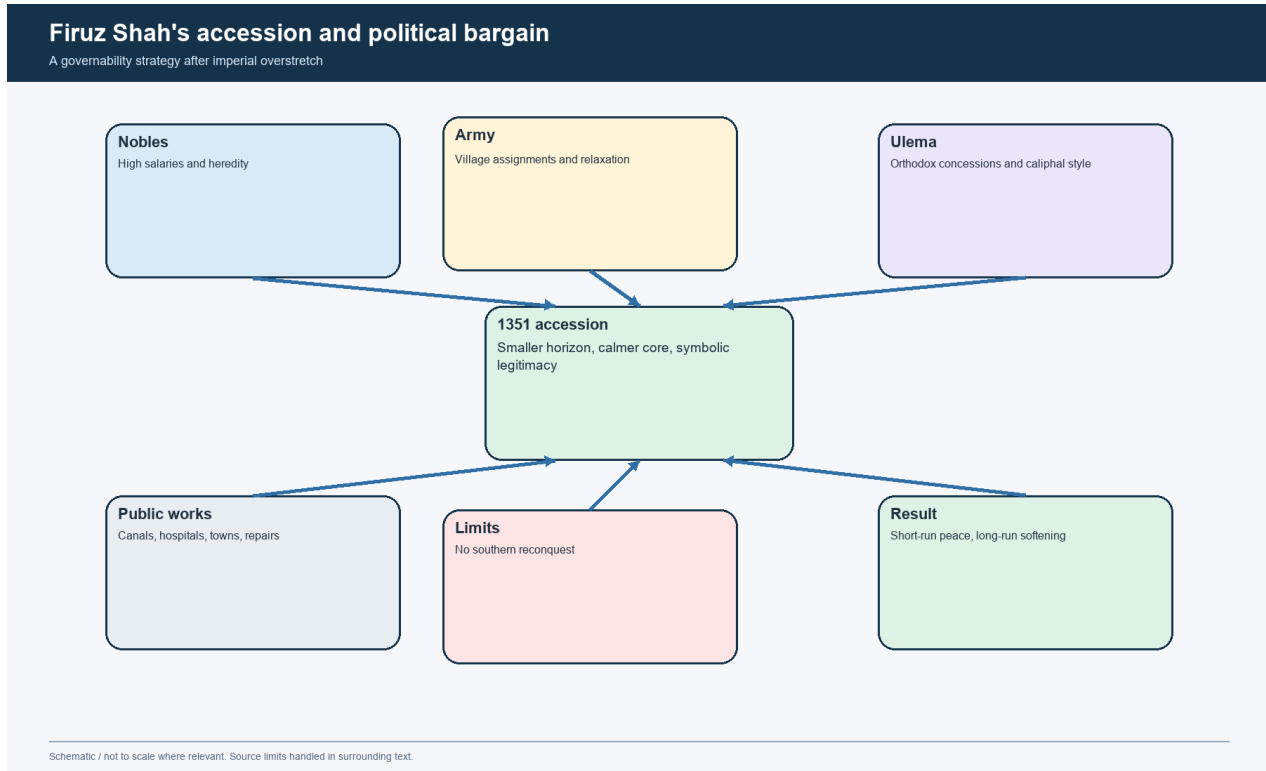
[FACT] Firuz Shah Tughlaq came to power in **1351** after Muhammad's death during the Sindh/Thatta phase. He inherited a shrinking but still large north-Indian Sultanate, with the south already gone, Bengal independent and nobles, soldiers and theologians all in need of reassurance.

[FACT] The concise OCR is clear about his governing choice: he would appease the nobles, the army and the theologians, and would assert authority only over areas that could be administered from the centre without impossible strain.

[FACT] He made no serious attempt to recover the south or reimpose direct rule over the Deccan. Two Bengal campaigns failed; raids into Jajnagar (Orissa) and Nagarkot produced plunder or acknowledgment but no enduring extension; the long Thatta campaign became a lesson in the cost of military overreach.

[ANALYSIS] Firuz's accession therefore marks a political bargain. If Muhammad tried to make the empire uniform, Firuz tried to make the remaining Sultanate governable by lowering coercive temperature and accepting a smaller horizon of ambition.

[FACT] He also sought caliphal investiture and robes of honour, but the advanced OCR treats this as symbolic prestige rather than the foundation of power.



13. Firuz Shah's accession and political bargain

Accession visual. Firuz's strength lay less in conquest than in redefining what the centre would now try to hold and whom it would placate.

Bargain table

Constituency	Firuz's offer	Long-term cost
Nobles	High salaries, heredity, softer audit	Stronger oligarchic claims
Army	Village assignments, heredity, relaxed inspection	Lower discipline and central readiness
Ulema	Symbolic orthodoxy and concessions	Narrower ideological climate
Urban/core society	Public works, charity, hospitals, lower punitive terror	Concentration of benefits in core regions and favoured groups

15. Hereditary offices, iqta and military relaxation: the logic of elite conciliation

[FACT] Firuz decreed that when a noble died, his office and often his **iqta** should pass to his son, son-in-law or, failing them, even a slave. He also stopped the earlier practice of torturing nobles or their agents when account deficits were found during audit.

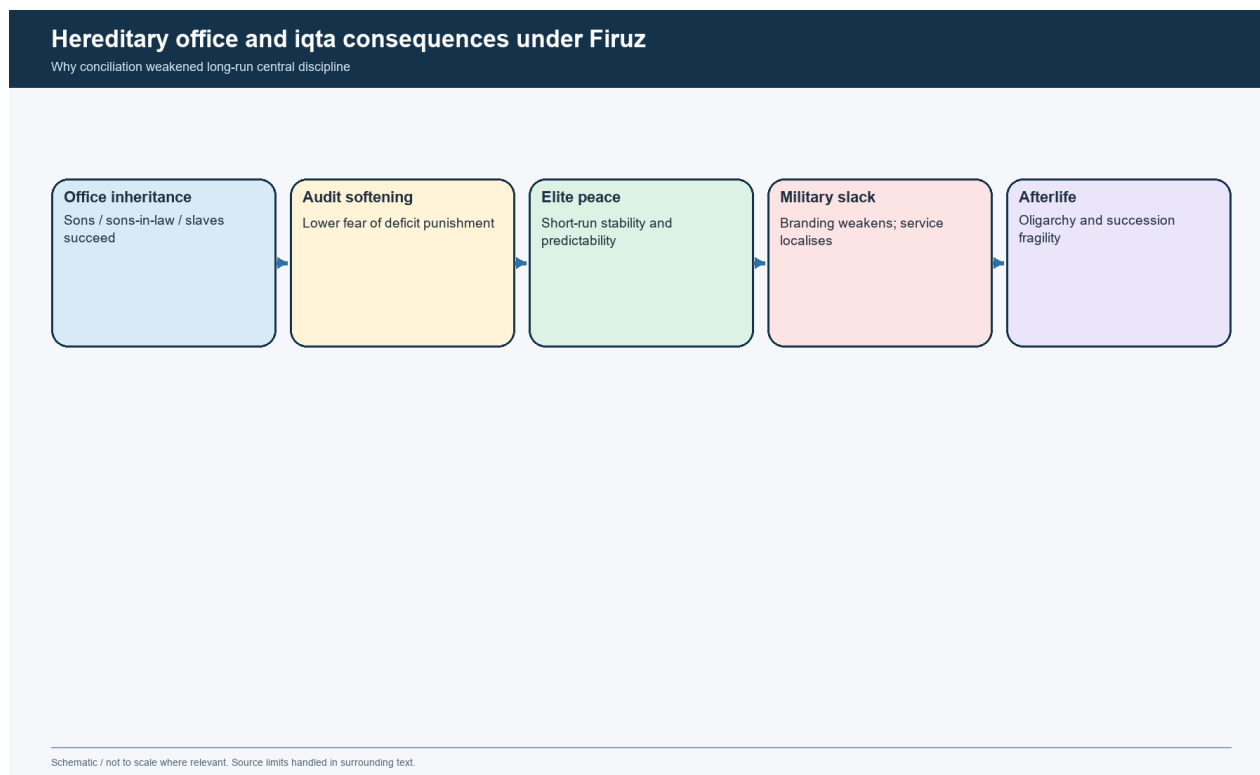
[FACT] A new revenue valuation was made early in the reign, but the *jama* was not revised later. As cultivation expanded, the holders of grants and offices often benefited automatically.

[FACT] Firuz extended the hereditary principle to the army. Old soldiers could send sons, sons-in-law or slaves in their place; large parts of the army were paid by assignments on village revenue (*wajh*) rather than cash.

[FACT] The advanced OCR also preserves the telling detail that horse-branding discipline weakened. Firuz repeatedly extended deadlines and even, in a famous anecdote, gave a soldier a gold tanka so that he could bribe the clerk to pass a deficient horse.

[ANALYSIS] This system worked as political insurance in the short run. It reduced noble rebellion, tied military families to rural income and lowered fear of audit. But it also narrowed recruitment, softened discipline and made the centre dependent on entrenched office-holding circles.

[LIMIT] Avoid the lazy formula "Firuz feudalised the state" unless you immediately explain the debate. The safer language is **heredity, localisation of claims and weakening of central audit-control**.



14. Hereditary iqta and office consequences flow

Consequence-flow visual. The same policy that stabilised the elite also hollowed out merit and discipline.

Structured judgement

Short-term gain	Long-term weakness
Noble peace and predictability	Oligarchic closure
Soldier family attachment to service	Reduced muster quality
Lower audit terror	Fiscal slack and patronage leakage
Fewer internal rebellions in reign	Fragile succession after the ruler's death

16. Firuz's revenue, cesses and irrigation tax: claim, implementation and limit

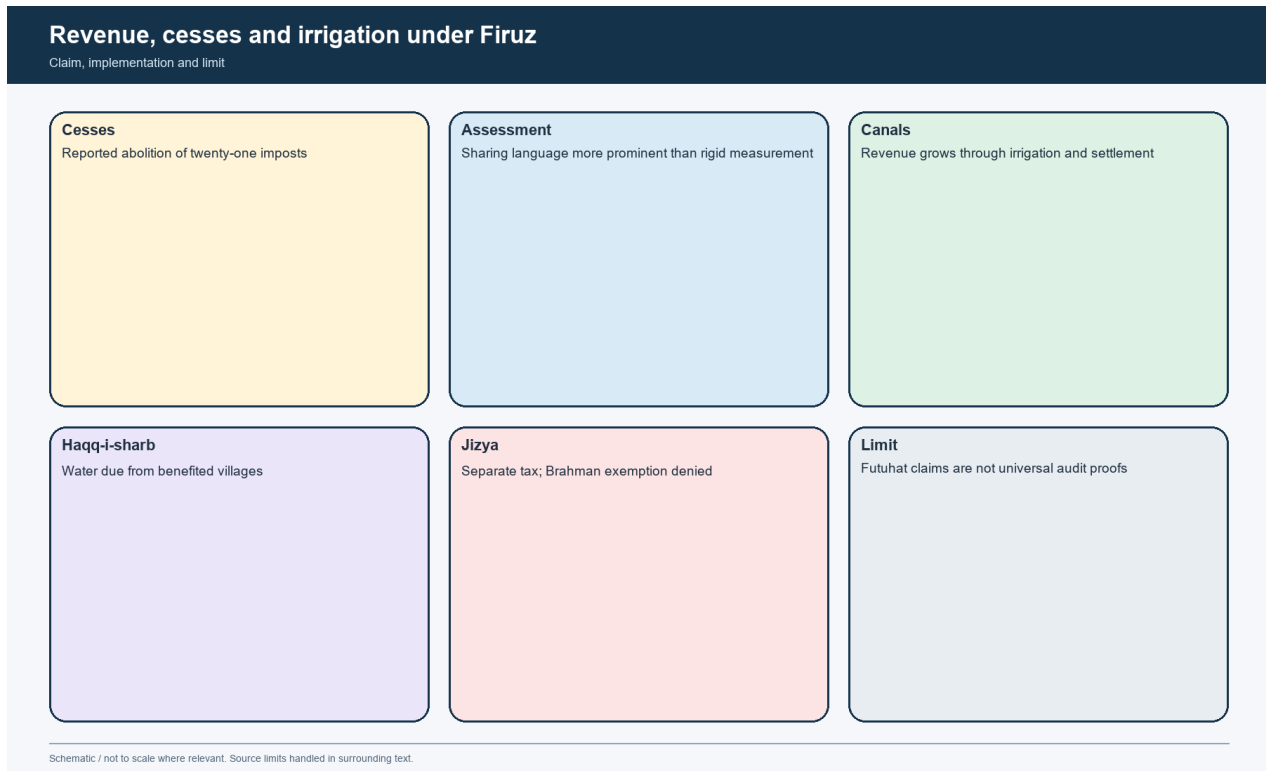
[FACT] Firuz Shah wanted to align taxation more closely with what he and his juristic advisers considered *shara*-sanctioned. Contemporary and later accounts say that he abolished **twenty-one cesses**, among them charges linked to markets and earlier levies such as *ghari*.

[FACT] The advanced OCR says that the fresh valuation by Khwaja Hisamuddin Junaid was made on inspection and that the basis of assessment was **sharing**, not rigid measurement. That distinction matters because it helps explain why Firuz's regime presented itself as more accommodative than Muhammad's doab policy.

[FACT] Canal irrigation generated an additional **haqq-i-sharb** of ten per cent from benefited villages. This formed part of the Sultan's personal income. The ordinary land revenue of new villages in irrigated zones also strengthened the crown.

[FACT] Firuz also made **jizya** a separate tax and extended it to Brahmans, ending their practical exemption. This was part of the same effort to describe the tax order as juristically purified, even while many mundane compromises remained.

[LIMIT] The four-tax formula commonly linked to *Futuhāt-i Firuz Shahī* must be treated as a claim of correct order, not as proof that every locality actually lived under a perfectly simplified tax regime.



15. Revenue, cesses and irrigation-policy matrix

Policy-matrix visual. It separates what Firuz claimed, what he built and what the evidence can securely show.

Best formulation

- [ANALYSIS] Firuz's fiscal policy was not anti-revenue. It was an attempt to make revenue extraction **socially softer in method, developmental in the core, and more legible to orthodox juristic language**.
- [LIMIT] Because benefits concentrated in the core north-Indian belt and among office-holders, the policy cannot be read as a universal peasant charter.

17. Canals, gardens, towns and public works: developmental energy in the north-Indian core

[FACT] Firuz created a large department of public works and pursued irrigation aggressively. The advanced OCR records a long canal from the **Sutlej** toward **Hansi/Hisar**, another from the **Yamuna**, and additional canals in the Haryana-Delhi tract. These were meant both for irrigation and for supplying water to new settlements.

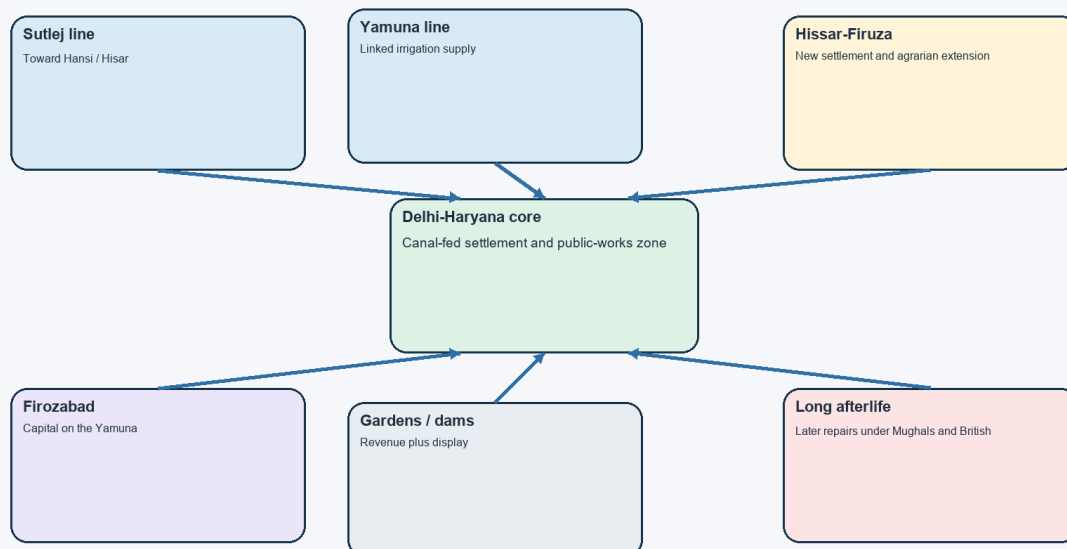
[FACT] The same source connects these canals to the founding of **Hissar-Firuzā/Hisar** and to wider agrarian expansion. The text also notes that later Mughal and British repair-and-extension gave some of these works a much longer institutional afterlife.

[FACT] Firuz built dams, planted orchards and is said to have created large numbers of gardens around Delhi. The reported income from orchards appears in the chronicles as part of the regime's developmental self-image.

[ANALYSIS] The real importance is spatial. Firuz's public works were concentrated in the **core northern tract** where the Sultanate still had the will and means to shape landscapes directly. They are evidence of state-building, but of a geographically narrower state than Muhammad had sought to command.

Canal and public-works network under Firuz

Indicative northern core; not to scale



Schematic / not to scale where relevant. Source limits handled in surrounding text.

16. Firuz Shah's canal and public-works network schematic

Public-works schematic. Routes are indicative and explicitly not to scale; the point is the concentration of works in the northern core.

Why this matters

Developmental move	Political meaning
Canal irrigation	State investment tied to revenue growth and agrarian recovery
New towns	Market nodes, control points and prestige markers
Orchards and gardens	Productive revenue plus courtly display
Dams and repairs	The state as custodian-builder, not only tax collector

18. Urbanism, architecture and conservation under Firuz: Kotla, Hauz Khas, old monuments and Ashokan pillars

[FACT] Tughlaq architecture carried forward the dynasty's austere idiom: battered walls, high platforms, grey stone and an effort to combine arch-principles with lintel-beam traditions. Ghiyasuddin's tomb and Tughlaqabad had already begun this visual language.

[FACT] Firuz founded or renewed urban spaces including **Firozabad** on the Yamuna, with the surviving fort now called **Kotla Firoz Shah**. The advanced OCR also associates him with Hissar-Firuz and with building or renovating Jaunpur, but this should be phrased cautiously because later regional histories add their own layers of attribution.

[FACT] Firuz repaired many earlier monuments: the advanced OCR explicitly mentions repairs to the **Qutb Minar**, old mosques and tombs, and the **Hauz Khas** complex. This is one reason his reign matters for medieval conservation history.

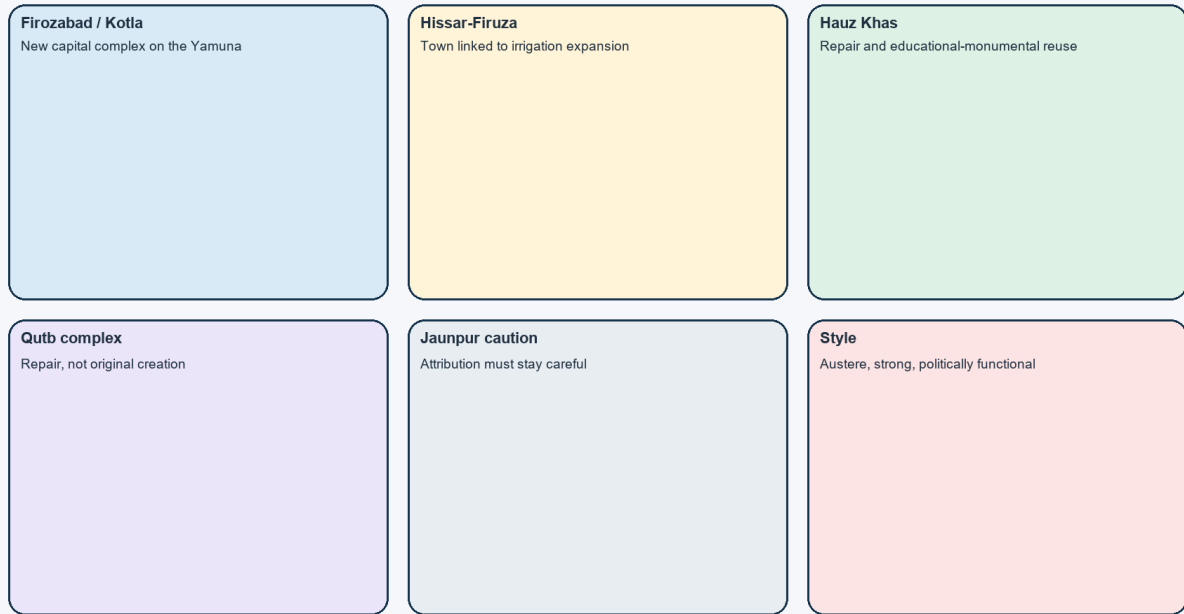
[FACT] Upinder Singh's local extract, using Afif and the illustrated *Sirat-i-Firuz Shahi*, provides unusually vivid evidence for the transport of the **Topra** and **Meerut** Ashokan pillars to Delhi. Tools, silk-cotton cushioning, a forty-two-wheeled carriage, river transport and palace re-erection together show both technical competence and ideological appropriation.

[ANALYSIS] Firuz's monument policy had three layers: practical repair, dynastic display and appropriation of prestigious older artefacts into a new political centre. It was not "heritage conservation" in the modern civic sense, but

it was certainly a medieval politics of preservation, reuse and inscriptional prestige.

Firuz Shah's urban and architectural works

Foundation, repair and prestige reuse



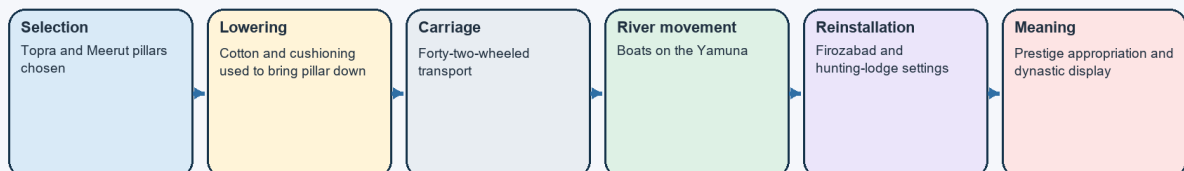
Schematic / not to scale where relevant. Source limits handled in surrounding text.

17. Firuz Shah's urban and architectural works matrix

Urban-works matrix. It distinguishes new foundation, repair and prestige appropriation.

Ashokan pillar transport under Firuz

Technical process with ideological meaning



Schematic / not to scale where relevant. Source limits handled in surrounding text.

18. Ashokan pillar transport and reinstallation process

Transport-process visual. The movement of the Topra pillar is both a technical and an ideological event.

Attribution caution

Claim	Safe wording
Firozabad	Firuz founded a new capital on the Yamuna; Kotla survives as the clearest remnant
Jaunpur	Firuz is associated in the advanced OCR with building or renovating it; later Sharqi development must be kept separate
Qutb repair	Firuz repaired/rebuilt damaged upper portions; do not credit him with the whole monument
Pillars	He transported the Topra and Meerut Ashokan pillars to Delhi; the later inscriptions and meanings remained layered

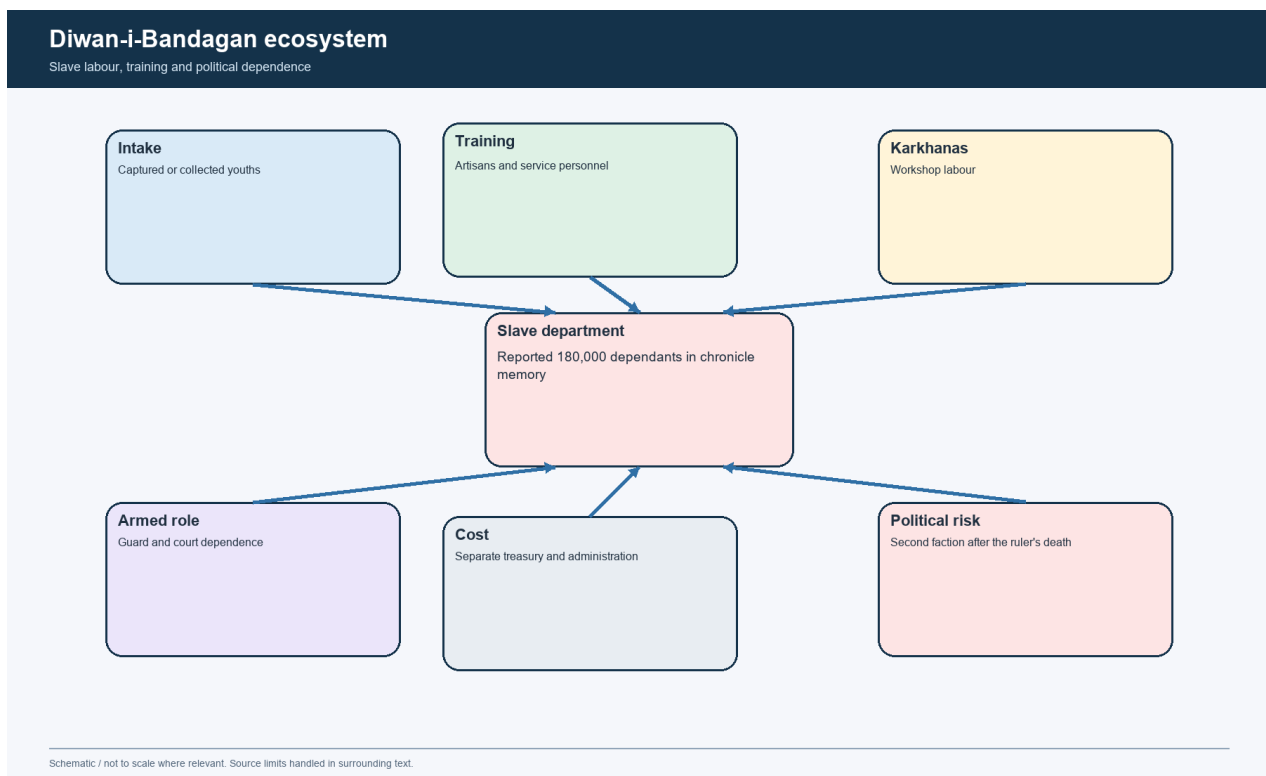
19. Slaves, Diwan-i-Bandagan and the political economy of coerced service

[FACT] Firuz ordered officials and victorious commanders to send selected boys and youths to him as slaves. The reported total reaches about **180,000**, with **12,000** trained as artisans. These are reported chronicle numbers and must remain labelled as such.

[FACT] The slaves served multiple functions: work in royal workshops (*karkhanas*), household and palace service, and an armed corps personally dependent on the ruler. A separate treasury, muster structure and administrative department existed for them.

[ANALYSIS] This was not a benevolent shelter-home. It was a system of coerced labour, political counterweight and court service that widened the ruler's direct dependants outside the regular nobility.

[LIMIT] The policy cut against Firuz's own stated aim of stable noble heredity. Instead of unifying the state, it created a second organised interest-group whose intervention became dangerous after the ruler's death.



19. Diwan-i-Bandagan slave-institution ecosystem

Institution-ecosystem visual. Intake, training, labour, military use and political side-effects are shown together.

Exam-safe conclusion

- [ANALYSIS] Firuz's slave system should be read as **state labour plus dynastic politics**, not as welfare, nor as a simple copy of early mamluk practice.

20. Charity, hospitals, marriages and "benevolence": who benefited and what were the limits?

[FACT] Firuz banned a range of mutilatory punishments in political and financial contexts, opened hospitals for free treatment, asked kotwals to prepare lists of the unemployed, arranged marriage assistance for poor girls and supported widows, orphans and the physically weak.

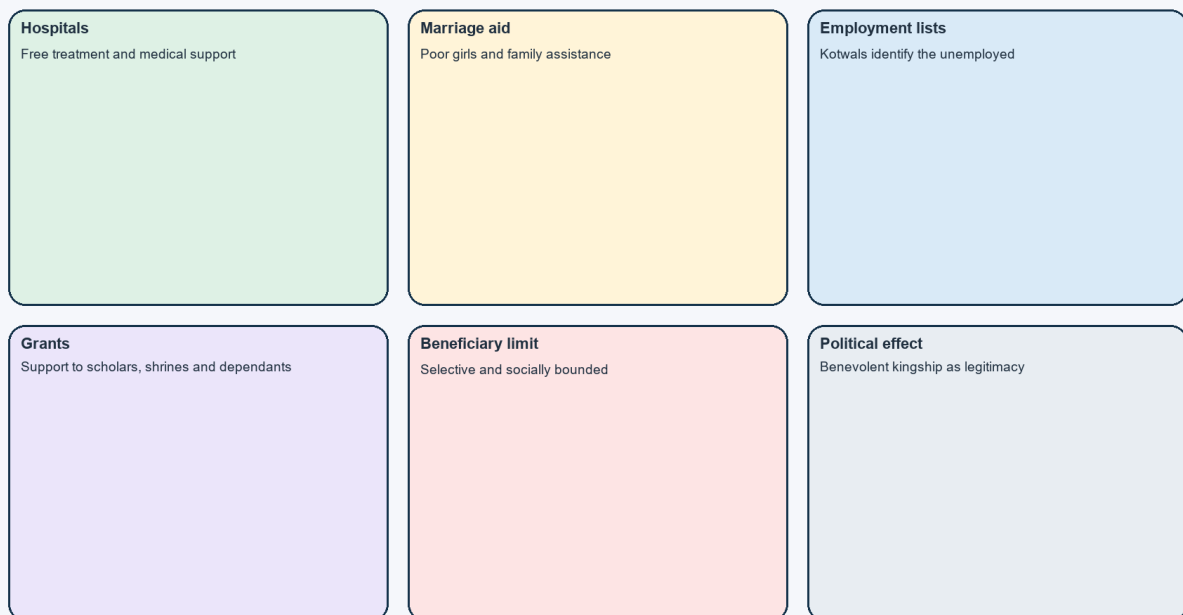
[FACT] He restored or increased many grants to theologians, scholars, shrines and associated dependants. These measures appear across chroniclers and within Firuz's own self-presentation.

[ANALYSIS] The key interpretive caution is about **beneficiaries**. The advanced OCR itself suggests that much of this help was intended above all for Muslims of respectable family status who had fallen on hard times, particularly around the capital. This is not the language of a universal welfare state.

[FACT] Even with those limits, Firuz's assertion that the state should not only punish and collect taxes but should also provide benevolent support marks a genuine ideological shift from the hard punitive reputation of the previous reign.

Benevolence, welfare claims and limits under Firuz

Who benefited, and how far?



Schematic / not to scale where relevant. Source limits handled in surrounding text.

20. Welfare departments, claims, beneficiaries and limits

Benevolence matrix. Claims are matched with likely beneficiary groups and historical limits.

Best wording

- [ANALYSIS] Firuz was not a modern social-welfare ruler; he was a medieval ruler who expanded the **language and some practice of benevolent kingship** while keeping it socially selective and politically useful.

21. Political conciliation and sharper religious orthodoxy: jizya, ulema, temples and translations

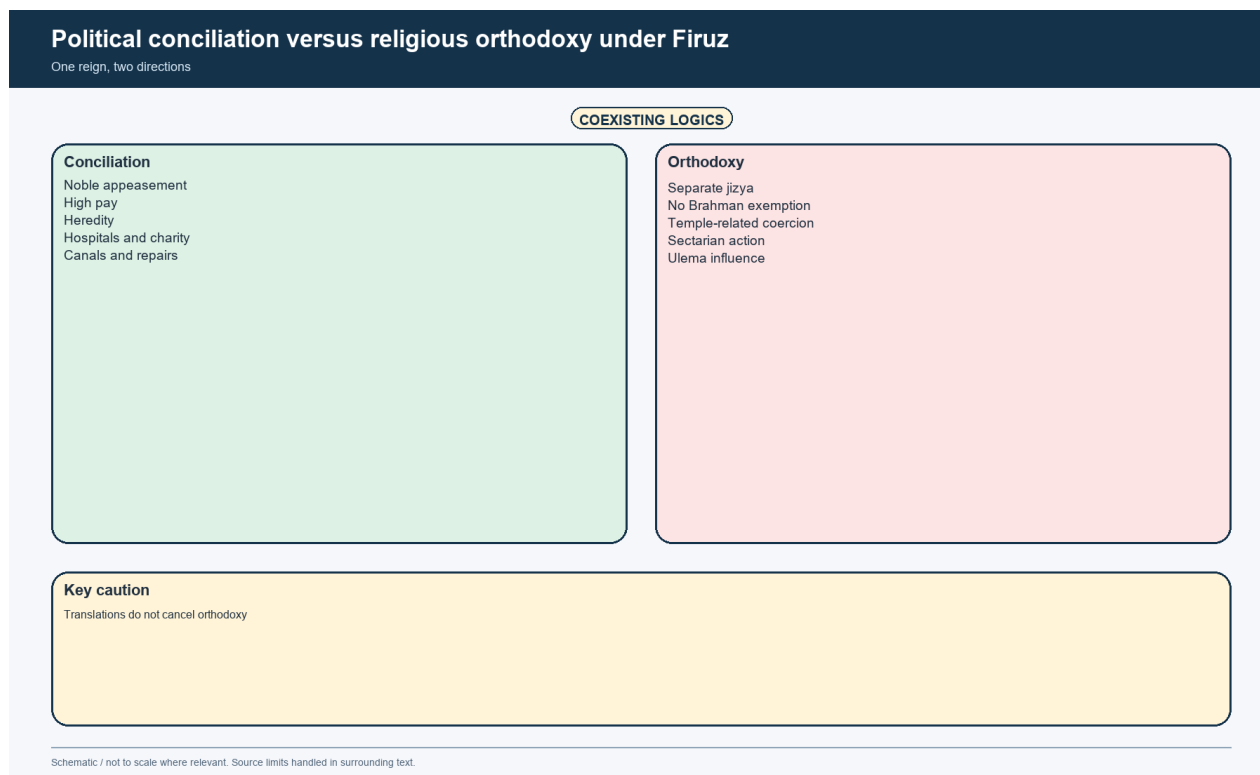
[FACT] Firuz tried to please the theologians by presenting himself as a properly Islamic ruler. He banned some practices they considered un-Islamic, persecuted some Muslim sects seen as heretical, and made **jizya** a separate tax while refusing to exempt Brahmins.

[FACT] The advanced and concise OCRs preserve severe episodes: the public burning of a Brahmin accused of preaching and conversion, the destruction of some newly built temples or festival-sites near Delhi, and restrictions on Muslim women's visits to saintly shrines.

[FACT] At the same time, Firuz patronised translations of Sanskrit works on **medicine, music and mathematics** into Persian and treated some Hindu chiefs with respect at court. This combination is why a one-word label is misleading.

[ANALYSIS] The right contrast is not "tolerant versus intolerant" in the abstract, but **political conciliation with elites and core society alongside sharper juristic marking of religious hierarchy**.

[LIMIT] Do not turn translation patronage into proof that orthodoxy was absent; do not turn jizya and temple action into proof that every aspect of rule was defined only by religious hostility.



21. Political conciliation versus religious orthodoxy

Comparison visual. Firuz's regime reduced one kind of coercion while sharpening another symbolic and juristic boundary.

Safe conclusion

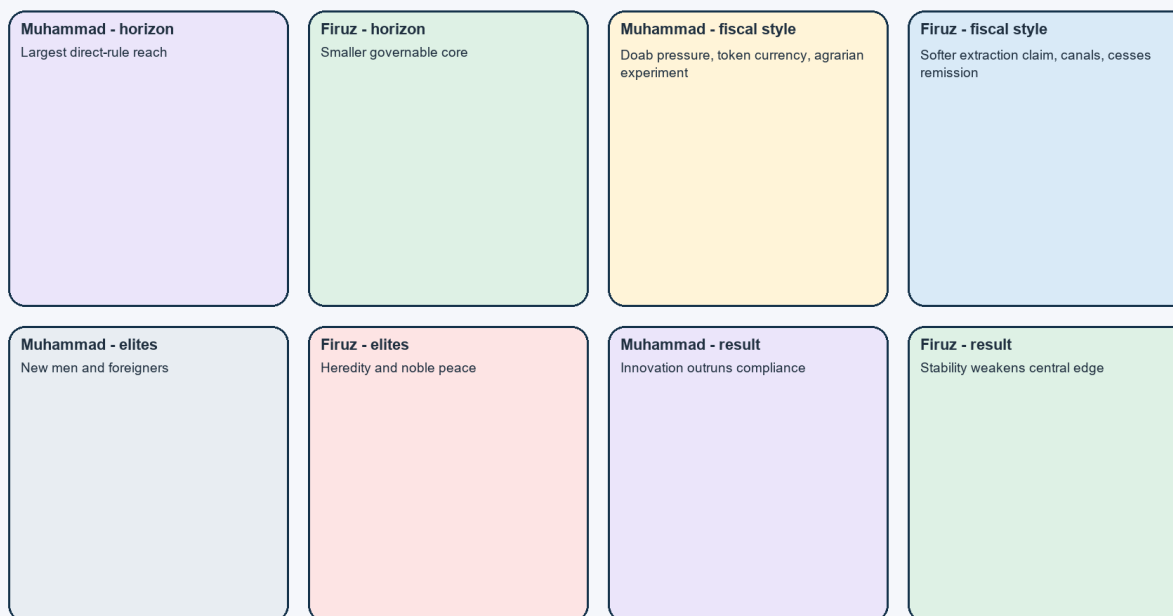
- [ANALYSIS] Firuz's state widened the discourse of benevolence but also strengthened orthodox authority. This tension is the key to the reign.

22. Muhammad versus Firuz: ambition, fiscal method, elite management, religion and durability

[ANALYSIS] The strongest comparison is structural. Muhammad tried to hold together a nearly pan-subcontinental empire by experimentation, direct supervision and uniformising pressure. Firuz accepted a smaller effective horizon and traded central sharpness for social peace in the north-Indian core.

Muhammad bin Tughlaq versus Firuz Shah

Structural comparison, not moral ranking



Schematic / not to scale where relevant. Source limits handled in surrounding text.

22. Muhammad versus Firuz structural matrix

Comparative visual. The contrast is not rationality versus irrationality or kindness versus cruelty; it is two different state strategies under pressure.

Comparison matrix

Dimension	Muhammad bin Tughlaq	Firuz Shah Tughlaq
Territorial imagination	Direct-rule expansion to the south and frontier offensives	Acceptance of a reduced but governable northern Sultanate
Fiscal strategy	Heavy assessment, monetisation experiment, developmental loans	Softer extraction claims, irrigation works, heredity-linked grant benefits
Elite management	Wider and riskier recruitment, including "new men" and foreigners	Conciliation, heredity, high salaries and audit relaxation
Religious politics	Observant yet intellectually open; conflict with orthodox ulema; caliphal rescript sought late	More demonstrative orthodoxy; jizya separate; ulema concessions alongside translations
Durability	Great ambition, weak credibility after failures	Long peace, but deeper institutional softening for the future

Best thesis sentence

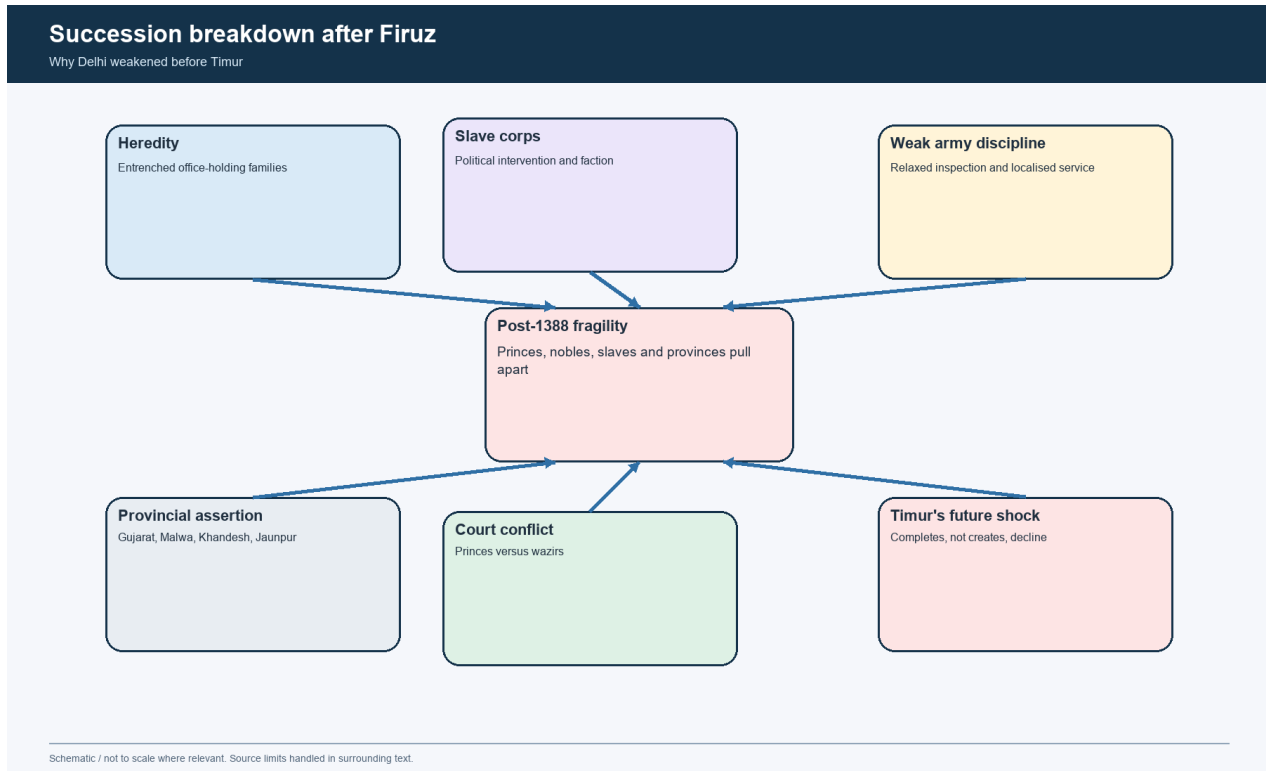
- [ANALYSIS] Muhammad stressed **innovation without secure compliance**; Firuz stressed **stability without secure central discipline**.

23. Succession, slaves, nobles and post-1388 instability: why the Sultanate weakened before Timur

[FACT] Even before Firuz died, conflict had broken out between Prince Muhammad and the wazir Khan-i-Jahan II. The slave corps intervened, princely alignments shifted, and joint-sovereignty experiments failed to stabilise succession.

[FACT] After Firuz's death in **1388**, repeated struggles among sons and grandsons followed. The slaves tried to play king-maker and failed; provincial governors in Gujarat, Malwa, Khandesh and Jaunpur asserted autonomy; local chiefs withheld revenue; Delhi's practical zone contracted.

[ANALYSIS] Timur's sack of Delhi in 1398-99 was therefore a **completing shock**, not the single creator of decline. The groundwork had already been laid by hereditary office, military slackness, factional duality between nobles and slave corps, and unresolved succession.



23. Succession breakdown causal web

Breakdown visual. The aim is to show cumulative fragility, not one-cause collapse.

Handoff to Topic 06

- [FACT] Topic 05 stops with the causal web of weakening.
- [FACT] Topic 06 owns the full narrative of Timur, the Sayyids, Lodis and the fifteenth-century north-Indian balance of power.

24. Historiography, historical significance and the GS-I answer spine

[DEBATE] Older moralising narratives pushed Muhammad bin Tughlaq toward the labels "genius," "visionary" or "madman." The more defensible line, supported by the local sources, is a **state-capacity reading**: many policies had a rational objective, but they demanded trust, information and coordinated enforcement that the Sultanate could not reliably supply across that scale.

[DEBATE] Firuz has often been remembered as a welfare monarch. The local archive supports the public-works and benevolence side, but it also strongly supports the view that his conciliation strengthened oligarchy, relaxed audit, sharpened orthodoxy and weakened the army's quality.

[FACT] Historically, the Tughlaq phase matters because it marks the **widest reach of the Delhi Sultanate**, the clearest demonstration of pre-Mughal administrative overstretch, the transmission of north-Indian political culture into the Deccan, the most visible medieval canal-development effort in the north-Indian core, and the institutional road to post-1388 fragmentation before Timur's intervention.

Historiography comparison

Move beyond 'wise fool' and 'welfare king'

STATE-CAPACITY LENS

Caricatures

Muhammad = mad genius
Firuz = benevolent saint

Better method

Ask about objective, instrument, compliance, elite bargain and durability

Muhammad corrected

Rational aims, weak sequencing

Firuz corrected

Public works + orthodoxy + decentralising heredity

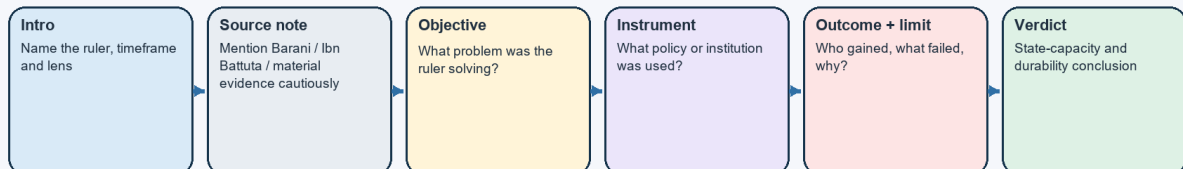
Schematic / not to scale where relevant. Source limits handled in surrounding text.

24. Historiography comparison: caricature versus capacity analysis

Historiography visual. It shows how to move from loaded adjectives to analyzable categories.

GS-I answer spine for the Tughlaqs

A reusable writing structure



Schematic / not to scale where relevant. Source limits handled in surrounding text.

25. GS-I answer spine for the Tughlaq topic

Answer-spine visual. Use it to structure a 10-, 15- or 20-mark response without collapsing policy, source and significance.

Final thematic verdict

- [ANALYSIS] The Tughlaqs show that medieval imperial power did not fail only because rulers were virtuous or vicious; it succeeded or failed according to how far **objectives, coercion, information, elite bargains and agrarian credibility** could be aligned.

PART II - Learning MCQ loops

Rotation check rule: Every original sequence in this export rotates correct options **A -> B -> C -> D**. This section begins that cycle.

Learning MCQ 01

Question: Which statement best captures the significance of Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq's accession for Topic 05?

A. It restored dynastic authority after late Khalji collapse and created the immediate institutional handoff into Muhammad's reign. B. It ended the need for any further Deccan campaigning by Delhi. C. It replaced all earlier administrative practices with a purely tribal order. D. It made Delhi's nobles permanently loyal to the new dynasty.

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Ghiyasuddin's reign matters because it restored order after Khusrau Khan, revived consolidation and created the political platform inherited by Muhammad bin Tughlaq.

Learning MCQ 02

Question: Which statement about the Daulatabad move is the safest according to the local evidence used in this package?

A. Delhi was fully depopulated and ceased to function. B. Daulatabad functioned as a second-capital project, with heavy pressure mainly on elites and service groups rather than the total population of Delhi. C. The move was a purely religious pilgrimage strategy. D. The policy had no long-term effect on the Deccan.

Correct answer: B

Explanation: The source-backed line is that Daulatabad was a second-capital experiment. Pressure was coercive, but the total-emptying myth is not sustainable.

Learning MCQ 03

Question: Muhammad bin Tughlaq's token-currency experiment is best described as:

A. an early paper-currency scheme copied from Europe. B. a barter-reform policy replacing coinage with grain notes. C. a copper-and-brass fiduciary coinage that failed because state control over authentication and counterfeiting was weak. D. a temple-donation currency used only in the Deccan.

Correct answer: C

Explanation: The experiment used metal token coinage, not paper. Its key fault line was credibility and forgery control.

Learning MCQ 04

Question: The doab crisis under Muhammad bin Tughlaq is most convincingly explained by which combination?

A. Purely peasant dislike of monetisation, without any climatic stress. B. A deliberate abolition of agriculture by the court. C. Peaceful refusal to migrate to Daulatabad. D. Rigid assessment, oppressive collection and famine-like environmental stress interacting with each other.

Correct answer: D

Explanation: The best explanation combines policy, collection practices and climate. No one-cause story is sufficient.

Learning MCQ 05

Question: The Diwan-i-Amir-i-Kohi is most accurately associated with:

A. state-backed cultivation extension, agricultural loans and attempts at crop improvement. B. replacing the iqta system with village republics. C. creating a naval department for Gujarat. D. organising the Topra pillar transport.

Correct answer: A

Explanation: The department targeted agrarian extension and improvement through loans and supervision, though implementation failed badly.

Learning MCQ 06

Question: Which statement correctly distinguishes the Khurasan project from the Qarachil expedition?

A. Both were attempts to conquer China. B. The Khurasan project concerned the north-western strategic frontier, whereas Qarachil was a Himalayan campaign shaped by terrain and logistics. C. Khurasan was a Bengal tax reform and Qarachil a canal. D. Khurasan succeeded fully while Qarachil never began.

Correct answer: B

Explanation: The package stresses that the two enterprises must not be conflated. One is a frontier-strategy question; the other is a mountain-expedition problem.

Learning MCQ 07

Question: Barani's hostility to Muhammad bin Tughlaq's "low-born" or non-traditional appointees is most useful as evidence for:

A. the total absence of talent among those officials. B. a democratic revolution in the Delhi Sultanate. C. aristocratic prejudice within the chronicler's own political world. D. the end of all provincial administration.

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Barani's language reveals elite bias. It cannot simply be taken as proof that every such appointment was incompetent.

Learning MCQ 08

Question: Ibn Battuta is most valuable for Topic 05 when the historian wants to study:

A. exact all-India revenue statistics over multiple decades. B. a neutral village-by-village survey of agrarian life. C. the architecture of Mauryan stupas. D. court ritual, roads, travel conditions, gift-punishment culture and the atmosphere of Muhammad bin Tughlaq's rule.

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Ibn Battuta's strength lies in witnessed courtly practice and travel experience, not comprehensive structural statistics.

Learning MCQ 09

Question: Muhammad bin Tughlaq's religious politics are best understood as:

A. observant but intellectually open kingship that still clashed with orthodox intermediaries and resorted to harsh coercion. B. complete rejection of Islam in favour of a new state creed. C. pure saintly tolerance without punitive action. D. total ulema domination from the beginning of the reign.

Correct answer: A

Explanation: The local evidence shows observance, debate with multiple traditions, caliphal symbolism and sharp conflict with orthodox critics.

Learning MCQ 10

Question: Firuz Shah's accession strategy is best summarised as:

A. reconquering the entire south before consolidating Delhi. B. stabilising a smaller governable Sultanate through conciliation of nobles, soldiers and theologians. C. ending all iqta assignments immediately. D. abolishing public works in favour of frontier war.

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Firuz reduced horizon and emphasised conciliation rather than recreating Muhammad's scale of ambition.

Learning MCQ 11

Question: The hereditary transfer of offices and iqta under Firuz Shah most directly encouraged:

A. meritocratic widening of recruitment. B. tighter central audit over nobles. C. oligarchic closure and long-run weakening of central discipline. D. the abolition of village revenue assignments.

Correct answer: C

Explanation: The policy reduced fear and rebellion in the short run, but it entrenched hereditary office-holding and weakened discipline.

Learning MCQ 12

Question: In the fiscal language of Firuz Shah's reign, **haqq-i-sharb** referred to:

A. a war indemnity paid by Bengal. B. a customs duty on imported horses. C. a minting charge on copper coins. D. an irrigation-related water due collected from villages benefiting from canals.

Correct answer: D

Explanation: The package uses the advanced OCR's clear identification of *haqq-i-sharb* as a water due tied to canal benefit.

Learning MCQ 13

Question: Firuz Shah's transport of Ashokan pillars to Delhi is historically significant primarily because it shows:

A. technical skill, dynastic appropriation of older prestige and a politics of repair/reuse. B. the destruction of all pre-Islamic monuments in north India. C. abandonment of urban building in favour of pilgrimage. D. the first printing press in the Sultanate.

Correct answer: A

Explanation: The pillar episode combines engineering, display and appropriation; it does not fit either pure vandalism or modern conservation.

Learning MCQ 14

Question: The Diwan-i-Bandagan under Firuz Shah is best interpreted as:

A. a voluntary labour union. B. an organised system of slave labour, training and political dependence attached to the court. C. a merchants' guild of Multan. D. a frontier cavalry school for Mongol recruits only.

Correct answer: B

Explanation: The slave institution supported workshops, palace service and armed dependence; it was not a welfare body.

Learning MCQ 15

Question: Which statement best captures Firuz Shah's religious policy?

A. It completely ignored the ulema and abolished jizya. B. It replaced Islamic symbols with Persian royal ritual only. C. It combined political conciliation and benevolence with sharper juristic orthodoxy, including separate jizya and denial of Brahman exemption. D. It made all temple destruction narratives impossible by definition.

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Firuz's reign reduced one kind of coercion while sharpening orthodox marking; that combination is the key.

Learning MCQ 16

Question: Which comparison between Muhammad bin Tughlaq and Firuz Shah Tughlaq is the most defensible?

A. Muhammad failed because he had no coherent aims, while Firuz succeeded because he had none either. B. Muhammad and Firuz used identical instruments but got different luck. C. Muhammad was purely secular and Firuz purely religious. D. Muhammad pushed innovation and direct control beyond durable compliance, whereas Firuz purchased stability through conciliation that weakened long-run central power.

Correct answer: D

Explanation: This package's central comparison rests on different state strategies, not on shallow moral labels.

PART III - Solved practice workbook

PYQ verification ledger and scope honesty

- PYQ 01 - UPSC Prelims GS-I 2021 (directly relevant; statement wording verified locally; option row partially garbled in OCR, reconstructed only where secure).
- PYQ 02 - UPSC Prelims GS-I 2022 (adjacent but directly useful for Tughlaq-era Mongol chronology; wording verified locally).
- PYQ 03 - UPSC GS-I 2020 (adjacent source-criticism Mains question; wording preserved verbatim in repository and prior validated packages).
- PYQ 04 - UPSC GS-I 2023 (adjacent broader Sultanate-technology question; wording preserved verbatim in repository and prior validated packages).
- [LIMIT] Official Prelims answer keys for the locally used paper copies are not bundled with the evidence read in this export. Where the repository already uses a high-confidence inferred answer, that status is preserved explicitly as **inferred**, not falsely upgraded.

Verified and honestly-adjacent PYQs

PYQ 01 - UPSC Prelims GS-I 2021 (direct routed relevance; statement wording verified locally; option row partly garbled in local OCR)

Question as securely verified from the local paper OCR: Consider the following statements:

1. It was during the reign of Iltutmish that Chengiz Khan reached the Indus in pursuit of the fugitive Khwarezm prince.
2. It was during the reign of Muhammad bin Tughluq that Taimur occupied Multan and crossed the Indus.
3. It was during the reign of Deva Raya II of Vijayanagara Empire that Vasco da Gama reached the coast of Kerala.

Option row status: The local OCR preserves the options imperfectly, but the repository's earlier validated usage supports the standard combination row containing **1 only**, **1 and 2**, **3 only**, and **2 and 3**.

INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY: 1 only. Confidence: high.

Model explanation: Statement 1 is correct: Chengiz Khan reached the Indus while pursuing Jalal al-Din Mangburni during Iltutmish's reign. Statement 2 is incorrect because Timur's invasion belongs to the post-Firuz, post-Tughlaq-weakening phase and culminates in 1398-99, long after Muhammad bin Tughlaq. Statement 3 is incorrect because Vasco da Gama reached Kerala in 1498, during the age of a much later Vijayanagara ruler, not Deva Raya II.

Why this earns marks: It secures chronology by dynastic phase and stops the common trap of mechanically pairing "Muhammad bin Tughlaq" with every major north-western episode.

PYQ 02 - UPSC Prelims GS-I 2022 (adjacent frontier chronology question; exact wording verified locally)

Question: With reference to Indian history, consider the following statements:

1. The first Mongol invasion of India happened during the reign of Jalal-ud-din Khalji.
2. During the reign of Ala-ud-din Khalji, one Mongol assault marched up to Delhi and besieged the city.
3. Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq temporarily lost portions of north-west of his kingdom to Mongols.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) 1 and 2 (b) 2 only (c) 1 and 3 (d) 3 only

INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY: (b) 2 only. Confidence: high.

Model explanation: Statement 1 is incorrect because Mongol pressure predates Jalaluddin Khalji and belongs to an older north-western frontier chronology. Statement 2 is correct because the 1303 Targhi crisis brought Mongol pressure up to Delhi during Alauddin's reign. Statement 3 is unsafe as phrased and is not supported by the secure event-line used in this repository for Muhammad's frontier troubles.

Why this earns marks: It separates general Mongol pressure from specific Delhi-siege events and refuses to validate a statement merely because a familiar Tughlaq ruler is named.

PYQ 03 - UPSC GS-I 2020 (adjacent but highly useful source-criticism question; wording preserved in repository)

Question: Persian literary sources of medieval India reflect the spirit of the age. Comment. (Answer in 250 words)

Model answer:

Persian literary sources are indispensable for the Delhi Sultanate because they preserve the political language, moral anxieties and courtly horizons of the age. Yet they reflect the spirit of the age only when read with **genre, patronage and author-position caution**.

Topic 05 offers an ideal demonstration. **Barani** is central for Muhammad bin Tughlaq's token currency, Daulatabad, doab crisis and elite theory. But he was a later aristocratic moralist with open prejudice against the "low and ignoble"; his accounts often magnify exemplary success or failure to teach political lessons. **Isami** is useful for Deccan dislocation and Delhi overreach, but he writes from displacement and retrospective memory. **Ibn Battuta** gives vivid evidence on court ritual, punishments, gifts, roads and city-life under Muhammad, yet his traveller's gaze highlights the remarkable rather than the statistically normal. Under Firuz, **Afif** and the *Futuh-i Firuz Shahi* show public works, benevolence and orthodoxy, but they also stage the ruler's preferred self-image.

These texts therefore reflect not a neutral mirror-image of society, but the **refracted political culture** of their age: ideas of just rule, elite resentment, religious legitimacy, expansion, urbanity and fear. When paired with coins, canals, monuments and inscriptions, they become even more powerful.

Hence Persian literary sources do reflect the spirit of the age, but the spirit they reveal is courtly, argumentative and mediated - never transparent fact.

Why this earns marks: It uses Topic 05's source bank directly, names authors, explains what each source proves, and converts "reflect" into a method question rather than a slogan.

PYQ 04 - UPSC GS-I 2023 (adjacent broader Sultanate question; wording preserved in repository)

Question: What were the major technological changes introduced during the Sultanate period? How did those technological changes influence the Indian society? (Answer in 250 words)

Model answer:

The Sultanate period mattered technologically not because it created an entirely new civilisation, but because it accelerated the diffusion and combination of techniques in construction, military administration, irrigation and craft production. Their influence was strongest in **state capacity, urban growth and social differentiation**.

In construction, the stronger use of the **true arch, dome and lime mortar** enlarged the scale of buildings and changed the skyline of power. Topic 05's Tughlaq phase reveals a further turn toward battered defensive walls, elevated platforms and large repair projects under Firuz. In irrigation, canals associated with Firuz Shah show technology as agrarian development and revenue policy, not merely engineering. Their impact lay in settlement growth, cultivation expansion and the strengthening of the north-Indian core.

Administrative technology also mattered. Horse-branding, descriptive rolls and revenue audit systems show that information itself was a technology of rule. Even Muhammad bin Tughlaq's token-currency scheme, though it failed, belonged to the same world of technical experimentation tied to fiscal governance.

The social effect was uneven. These changes empowered states, towns, merchants, military systems and courtly centres more than they democratised society. Monumental architecture, canals and money policies deepened stratification even while widening circulation and urban connection.

Thus Sultanate technological change shaped Indian society by linking technique to power, production and urban order.

Why this earns marks: It answers both parts, uses Tughlaq-era examples rather than generic listing, and converts technology into social consequence.

Original broad-coverage MCQs

Rotation check rule: This second original sequence restarts at **A** and rotates strictly through **B, C, D**.

Broad MCQ 01

Question: Why does Topic 05 begin with Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq rather than only with Muhammad bin Tughlaq?

A. Because Ghiyasuddin created the dynastic legitimacy and immediate political platform inherited by Muhammad. B. Because no Khalji ruler ever existed before him. C. Because Ghiyasuddin founded Vijayanagara. D. Because Firuz Shah belonged to the same branch of Rajputs.

Correct answer: A

Explanation: The Tughlaq story begins with the 1320 takeover and Ghiyasuddin's consolidation, not only with Muhammad's experiments.

Broad MCQ 02

Question: Tughlaqabad is best understood as:

A. a pleasure garden with no political meaning. B. a fortified dynastic statement of military austerity and new legitimacy. C. a Mughal observatory. D. a Portuguese warehouse.

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Tughlaqabad proclaimed a new regime through a fortified, sloping-wall architectural idiom.

Broad MCQ 03

Question: Which is the safest statement regarding Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq's death?

A. It is fully proved as a saintly curse. B. It is fully proved as a deliberate murder by Muhammad bin Tughlaq. C. The secure event is the pavilion collapse; conspiracy and curse narratives belong to layered and disputed source traditions. D. There is no source at all about the event.

Correct answer: C

Explanation: The package separates secure event, suspicion and legend instead of choosing certainty where the evidence does not.

Broad MCQ 04

Question: Why are Muhammad bin Tughlaq's policies better read through a state-capacity lens than a personality caricature?

A. Because he never faced military problems. B. Because every policy succeeded once correctly explained. C. Because his reign had no relation to geography. D. Because many policies had intelligible aims but demanded coordination, trust and information that the Sultanate could not reliably supply.

Correct answer: D

Explanation: The state-capacity lens explains why rational aims could yield coercive failure.

Broad MCQ 05

Question: The choice of Daulatabad was politically meaningful chiefly because:

A. Devagiri was already a strategic Deccan base and more central to the enlarged imperial space. B. it lay closest to Tibet. C. it had never been touched by Delhi before. D. it had no settled population.

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Daulatabad was chosen from an existing strategic logic, not at random.

Broad MCQ 06

Question: Which statement corrects the standard textbook exaggeration about the Daulatabad move?

A. No one moved at all. B. Pressure fell especially on elites and service groups, while Delhi remained inhabited and continued to function. C. The move affected only Bengal. D. Coins ceased to be struck in Delhi forever.

Correct answer: B

Explanation: The secure correction is against total depopulation, not against all coercion.

Broad MCQ 07

Question: Muhammad bin Tughlaq's token-currency experiment should NOT be described as:

A. fiduciary coinage. B. a monetary experiment tied to credibility. C. paper currency. D. a policy undermined by forgery.

Correct answer: C

Explanation: The package explicitly rejects the common but incorrect label "paper currency."

Broad MCQ 08

Question: What most directly ruined the token-currency experiment?

A. Refusal of all nobles to accept any metal coin. B. A total absence of military expenditure. C. The closing of all mints by order of Firuz Shah. D. Failure to maintain trust by controlling authentication and counterfeiting.

Correct answer: D

Explanation: The issue was not novelty alone but the state's weak monopoly over verification.

Broad MCQ 09

Question: Which feature of the doab policy most sharply increased the effective burden on cultivators?

A. Assessment by standard yield and official prices rather than actual output and market reality. B. Complete abolition of revenue demand. C. Free canal irrigation for all India. D. Replacing officials with village assemblies only.

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Standard-yield rigidity under stress was central to the crisis.

Broad MCQ 10

Question: Muhammad bin Tughlaq's move to Swargadwari in the famine phase indicates:

A. permanent abandonment of Delhi for Bengal. B. the severity of scarcity and pestilential conditions around Delhi during the agrarian crisis. C. his conversion into a forest ascetic. D. the start of the Bahmani kingdom.

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Swargadwari belongs to the relief-and-crisis sequence linked to the doab distress and famine.

Broad MCQ 11

Question: The most careful interpretation of Diwan-i-Amir-i-Kohi is that it aimed to:

A. destroy cultivated land in the doab. B. create a seaborne customs network. C. extend cultivation onto banjar land while improving crops through loans and supervision. D. replace nobles with village priests.

Correct answer: C

Explanation: The advanced OCR encourages the more precise reading of agricultural extension rather than impossible cultivation of unusable soil.

Broad MCQ 12

Question: What is the safest caution when discussing the Khurasan project?

A. It certainly conquered Iraq. B. It had no relation to the north-west frontier. C. It was identical to the Qarachil expedition. D. Chroniclers inflate its scale and aim, so it should be treated as a strategic frontier project rather than automatic proof of world-conquest fantasy.

Correct answer: D

Explanation: The package keeps the project within a strategic frontier frame and marks exaggerated chronicler claims.

Broad MCQ 13

Question: The Qarachil expedition is best described as:

A. a Himalayan campaign wrecked by terrain and over-extension. B. a purely maritime expedition to Arabia. C. the founding of Firozabad. D. the abolition of jizya.

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Qarachil belongs to mountain logistics, not to China or overseas war.

Broad MCQ 14

Question: Which statement best connects Muhammad bin Tughlaq's southern losses to later regional states?

A. Delhi's southern failures automatically created a stable pan-Indian federation. B. Plague, distance and repeated rebellion weakened Delhi's direct rule, creating the setting for successor powers such as Vijayanagara and Bahmani. C. The south remained completely unaffected by Delhi's crises. D. Bengal created the Bahmani state.

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Topic 05 treats Vijayanagara and Bahmani as outcomes of Delhi overstretch, while full state histories remain elsewhere.

Broad MCQ 15

Question: Barani's complaints about Muhammad bin Tughlaq appointing "mean and ignoble" men are most valuable because they reveal:

A. that no such officials ever existed. B. that all service castes ruled the empire successfully. C. elite resentment at widened recruitment and changing access to office. D. the end of Persian as a court language.

Correct answer: C

Explanation: The phrase is evidence about aristocratic ideology as much as about administration.

Broad MCQ 16

Question: What is the chief limitation of Ibn Battuta for reconstructing the Tughlaq state?

A. He never visited India. B. He wrote only about Gupta temples. C. He served only Firuz Shah. D. He is strongest on courtly and travel experience, not on comprehensive village-level structural data.

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Ibn Battuta is vivid and valuable, but his genre and location limit the scope of his evidence.

Broad MCQ 17

Question: Muhammad bin Tughlaq's turn toward caliphal investiture and the Caliph's name on coins is best explained as:

A. an attempt to answer orthodox hostility by reinforcing symbolic legitimacy. B. a rejection of all Islamic political language. C. a revenue measure to fund canal digging under Firuz. D. a sign that Bengal had become the capital.

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Caliphal symbolism was used to answer critics, though it did not fully solve the legitimacy problem.

Broad MCQ 18

Question: Firuz Shah's accession differed from Muhammad bin Tughlaq's imperial style because Firuz:

A. immediately reconquered the deep south. B. accepted a smaller, more governable horizon and sought stability through conciliation. C. ended all concern for revenue. D. abandoned urban building.

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Firuz's political bargain rested on governability, not on renewed all-India direct-rule ambition.

Broad MCQ 19

Question: The hereditary transfer of offices and iqṭas under Firuz Shah most clearly encouraged:

A. stronger meritocracy. B. permanent elimination of noble privilege. C. entrenchment of office-holding families and weakening of central discipline. D. the disappearance of rural revenue assignments.

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Heredity reduced rebellion in the short run but deepened long-run oligarchic weakness.

Broad MCQ 20

Question: Why is Firuz Shah's jizya policy important for Topic 05?

A. It proves that all other taxes vanished overnight. B. It shows that Brahmans became army commanders by right. C. It had no relation to orthodoxy. D. It illustrates Firuz's sharper juristic ordering of rule, including denial of the earlier practical Brahman exemption.

Correct answer: D

Explanation: The jizya issue is central to understanding Firuz's combination of benevolence and orthodoxy.

Broad MCQ 21

Question: Under Firuz Shah, many soldiers of the central army were paid through:

A. village-revenue assignments known as *wajh*. B. only imported Venetian silver. C. temple management rights in Odisha. D. a fully salaried navy based at Cambay.

Correct answer: A

Explanation: The advanced OCR explicitly notes payment through village assignments, reinforcing heredity and localisation.

Broad MCQ 22

Question: In Topic 05, *haqq-i-sharb* is best understood as:

A. a slave-market cess. B. a water due or irrigation tax linked to canal benefit. C. a tax on paper manuscripts. D. the salary of Ibn Battuta.

Correct answer: B

Explanation: It refers to an irrigation-related levy, not to a general trade or market tax.

Broad MCQ 23

Question: Which statement about Firuz Shah's architectural and urban activity is the safest?

A. Every later city in north India was entirely his foundation. B. He destroyed all older monuments and built only new ones. C. He founded or renewed important urban sites, repaired earlier monuments and must be discussed with careful attribution rather than inflated total credit. D. He had no connection at all with Hauz Khas or Kotla.

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Attribution must be precise: Firuz was a major builder and repairer, but not the sole creator of every later urban centre.

Broad MCQ 24

Question: The movement of the Topra and Meerut Ashokan pillars to Delhi is most important because it demonstrates:

A. the end of all inscriptional culture. B. Firuz Shah's rejection of older political symbols. C. that Tughlaq rulers lacked engineering knowledge. D. a fusion of technical transport skill, prestige appropriation and dynastic self-display.

Correct answer: D

Explanation: The pillar episode is both a technological feat and an ideological act.

Broad MCQ 25

Question: The Diwan-i-Bandagan is best described as:

A. an organised apparatus managing a large body of slaves for labour, service and political dependence. B. a voluntary marriage bureau. C. a literary academy founded by Ibn Battuta. D. a mint-control office for token currency.

Correct answer: A

Explanation: The institution tied slave labour, palace service and power politics together.

Broad MCQ 26

Question: What is the sharpest limitation in calling Firuz Shah a "welfare monarch"?

- A. He never undertook any charitable measure.
- B. Much of the benevolence was selective, politically useful and concentrated among favoured or respectable groups rather than universally distributed.
- C. He abolished all hospitals.
- D. He ruled only in the Deccan.

Correct answer: B

Explanation: The welfare label needs qualification because beneficiaries and motives were selective.

Broad MCQ 27

Question: Firuz Shah's patronage of translations from Sanskrit into Persian should lead to which conclusion?

- A. Orthodoxy disappeared from the reign.
- B. Jizya lost all significance.
- C. Cultural interest and orthodox state-marking could coexist in the same reign.
- D. The ulema had no role in politics.

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Translation patronage does not cancel the evidence for sharper juristic orthodoxy.

Broad MCQ 28

Question: Firuz Shah's claim to have reduced mutilatory punishment should be read as:

- A. proof that coercion vanished from the Sultanate.
- B. evidence that no rebellion occurred after 1351.
- C. a meaningless invention unsupported by any source tradition.
- D. part of a benevolent self-presentation that reduced one style of punishment without eliminating power or coercion.

Correct answer: D

Explanation: The package treats the claim as meaningful but not as proof of a non-coercive state.

Broad MCQ 29

Question: Which summary of Firuz Shah's military career is the safest?

- A. Mixed campaigns in Bengal, Jainagar, Nagarkot and Sindh, combined with refusal to attempt southern reconquest.
- B. Total reconquest of the south and Bengal alike.
- C. Exclusive focus on sea-borne warfare.
- D. Complete military inactivity.

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Firuz campaigned, but with limited durable results and no return to Muhammad's southern ambition.

Broad MCQ 30

Question: Firuz Shah's repeated search for caliphal investiture is best interpreted as:

- A. proof that the Caliph directly governed Delhi.
- B. a symbolic reinforcement of legitimacy rather than a source of real executive power.
- C. a sign that Firuz abandoned Islam.
- D. evidence that Bengal had accepted his suzerainty permanently.

Correct answer: B

Explanation: By Firuz's time, caliphal prestige remained useful symbolically even though practical power lay elsewhere.

Broad MCQ 31

Question: Why must the *Futuh-i Firuz Shahi* be read carefully?

- A. Because it contains no political material.
- B. Because it was written by Chengiz Khan.
- C. Because it is a ruler's self-presentation and must be checked against other narrative and material evidence.
- D. Because it deals only with Portuguese trade.

Correct answer: C

Explanation: The *Futuh* is valuable precisely because it reveals how Firuz wanted to be remembered.

Broad MCQ 32

Question: Which comparison most clearly distinguishes Muhammad bin Tughlaq from Firuz Shah?

A. Muhammad disliked administration while Firuz invented it. B. Muhammad and Firuz both relied only on saints. C. Muhammad ruled a smaller territory than Firuz. D. Muhammad pursued high-risk innovation and direct supervision, whereas Firuz sought durable calm through conciliation and heredity.

Correct answer: D

Explanation: This contrast captures the package's core comparative framework.

Broad MCQ 33

Question: Which factor most directly worsened post-1388 instability?

A. Interaction of hereditary office, factional nobles, ambitious princes and the slave corps. B. Immediate reconquest of Madurai by Delhi. C. Elimination of all provincial governors. D. Permanent unity between princes and wazirs.

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Succession weakness was cumulative and involved more than one courtly constituency.

Broad MCQ 34

Question: Timur's later invasion should be connected to Topic 05 in which way?

A. As the single original cause of Tughlaq decline. B. As a culminating shock that struck a Sultanate already weakened by earlier structural and succession problems. C. As an event of Muhammad bin Tughlaq's youth. D. As proof that Firuz recovered the Deccan.

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Topic 05 builds the preconditions; Topic 06 owns the full Timur narrative.

Broad MCQ 35

Question: Why is the Tughlaq phase historically significant in the larger Sultanate story?

A. It eliminated regional states permanently. B. It ended all north-south political contact. C. It combined the widest Delhi reach, dramatic over-stretch, Deccan political consequences and important northern irrigation-public-works initiatives. D. It introduced no notable administrative or political shift.

Correct answer: C

Explanation: The Tughlaq age is historically important both for expansion and for the visible limits of such expansion.

Broad MCQ 36

Question: The most defensible historiographical line on Muhammad bin Tughlaq is that he was:

A. simply insane and therefore beyond analysis. B. a saintly planner betrayed only by fate. C. a ruler whose every policy was modern and democratic. D. an ambitious ruler with many rational aims whose sequencing, coercion and compliance mechanisms repeatedly failed.

Correct answer: D

Explanation: This avoids both caricature and romantic rescue.

Broad MCQ 37

Question: The most defensible historiographical line on Firuz Shah is that he was:

A. a benevolent developmental ruler whose public works coexisted with heredity, orthodoxy and long-run central weakening. B. identical in method to Muhammad bin Tughlaq. C. uninterested in agriculture or towns. D. a ruler about whom only European evidence exists.

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Firuz's reputation must include both developmental initiatives and institutional softening.

Broad MCQ 38

Question: Which architectural feature is most closely associated with Tughlaq style in this package?

A. Extensive marble pietra dura panels. B. Battered or sloping walls combined with an austere fortified idiom. C. Circular Buddhist railings. D. Neo-classical porticoes.

Correct answer: B

Explanation: The package repeatedly uses the sloping-wall fortified style as a Tughlaq marker.

Broad MCQ 39

Question: Why are coins, canals, forts and pillars important alongside chronicles in Topic 05?

A. They replace all written sources completely. B. They prove that every chronicle number is exact. C. They anchor claims in material action while reminding us that physical survival does not automatically equal full administrative control. D. They matter only for ancient history.

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Material evidence is a corrective, not an omniscient substitute.

Broad MCQ 40

Question: Which one-line conclusion best sums up this workbook's argument?

A. Medieval rule can be explained entirely through morality tales. B. Policy failure proves absence of purpose. C. Benevolence alone guarantees stability. D. The Tughlaq story is best read through the fit - or misfit - between ambition, information, coercion, revenue and elite management.

Correct answer: D

Explanation: This is the package's master analytical sentence.

Remedial MCQs - trap-correction set

Rotation check rule: This third original sequence restarts at **A** and rotates strictly through **B, C, D**.

Remedial MCQ 01

Question: Which correction best defeats the trap "Muhammad emptied Delhi completely"?

A. He imposed severe movement pressure, but mainly on elites and associated groups; Delhi remained inhabited and functioning. B. No movement occurred at all. C. Only Bengal was moved. D. Daulatabad never existed.

Correct answer: A

Explanation: The right correction is against total depopulation, not against coercion itself.

Remedial MCQ 02

Question: Which correction best defeats the trap "Muhammad introduced paper currency"?

A. The policy abolished coinage. B. The experiment used copper-and-brass token coinage, not paper currency. C. The currency was only ceremonial gold. D. Firuz Shah introduced it after 1351.

Correct answer: B

Explanation: This is one of the most common textbook mistakes and must be removed immediately.

Remedial MCQ 03

Question: Which correction best defeats the trap "Muhammad bin Tughlaq was simply mad"?

A. He never planned anything at all. B. Every policy succeeded perfectly. C. Many policies had rational aims, but their sequencing and enforcement outran the state's capacity. D. Chroniclers never criticised him.

Correct answer: C

Explanation: The state-capacity lens beats both caricature and romantic overcorrection.

Remedial MCQ 04

Question: Which correction best defeats the trap "Qarachil was an expedition to conquer China"?

A. Qarachil was a canal. B. Qarachil took place in Bengal. C. Qarachil was a Portuguese embassy. D. Qarachil was a Himalayan campaign whose later "China" label is historically misleading.

Correct answer: D

Explanation: The package explicitly separates the mountain-campaign reality from later exaggeration.

Remedial MCQ 05

Question: Which correction best defeats the trap "Diwan-i-Kohi proves absurd farming of impossible desert land only"?

A. The more careful reading is agricultural extension onto banjar land with loans and supervision, though badly implemented. B. It was actually a minting reform. C. It had no relation to cultivation. D. It belonged to Firuz Shah's hospitals.

Correct answer: A

Explanation: The objective was risky but intelligible; the failure lay in execution.

Remedial MCQ 06

Question: Which correction best defeats the trap "Firuz Shah created a modern welfare state"?

A. He hated public works. B. His benevolence was real but selective, politically useful and embedded in a medieval social hierarchy. C. He ruled only temple priests. D. No chronicler mentions charity under him.

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Social selectivity is essential to any accurate description of Firuz's benevolence.

Remedial MCQ 07

Question: Which correction best defeats the trap "hereditary iqtas were an unqualified administrative success"?

A. Heredity instantly revived the Deccan. B. Heredity ended all faction. C. The policy purchased short-term calm but weakened merit, discipline and central control in the long run. D. The policy abolished all noble privilege.

Correct answer: C

Explanation: This is the central limitation of Firuz's conciliation strategy.

Remedial MCQ 08

Question: Which correction best defeats the trap "translation patronage proves Firuz Shah was not orthodox"?

A. Translation and orthodoxy can never coexist. B. Firuz did not patronise any translation at all. C. Jizya disappeared after translations began. D. Translation patronage coexisted with sharper juristic ordering, jizya enforcement and temple-related coercion.

Correct answer: D

Explanation: The reign must be read as a combination, not as a one-word identity.

Remedial MCQ 09

Question: Which correction best defeats the trap "the slave department was mainly a welfare institution"?

A. It organised coerced labour, service and political dependence rather than universal social protection. B. It was a merchants' port trust. C. It regulated Brahman taxes only. D. It built Tughlaqabad before 1320.

Correct answer: A

Explanation: The slave institution was part of court power and labour control.

Remedial MCQ 10

Question: Which correction best defeats the trap "Firuz's canals transformed every corner of the old Delhi empire equally"?

A. There were no canals at all. B. The works were concentrated in the north-Indian core and should not be inflated into empire-wide equal development. C. All canals were in Bengal only. D. The canals were built by Timur.

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Spatial concentration is essential to understanding Firuz's developmental model.

Remedial MCQ 11

Question: Which correction best defeats the trap "Barani's dramatic numbers and moral language can be taken literally throughout"?

A. Barani is useless and should be ignored. B. Material evidence can never check narrative. C. Barani is indispensable but rhetorical, later and aristocratic, so his claims require cross-checking and minimum-secure phrasing. D. His account was written by Ibn Battuta.

Correct answer: C

Explanation: The correct method is critical use, not blind faith or total rejection.

Remedial MCQ 12

Question: Which correction best defeats the trap "Timur alone caused the fall of the Tughlaqs"?

A. Timur restored the Tughlaqs. B. No decline had begun before 1398. C. Firuz's succession arrangements had already solved instability. D. Timur struck a Sultanate already weakened by heredity, faction, provincial assertion and succession crises.

Correct answer: D

Explanation: The package places Timur as a culminating shock, not as the sole originating cause.

Original solved Mains practice

Original Mains 01 - 10 marks - 150 words

Question: Assess the importance of Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq's short reign for understanding the wider Tughlaq age.

Model answer:

Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq matters less for duration than for **transition**. He ended the Khusrau Khan crisis in 1320 and restored dynastic legitimacy after the late Khalji collapse. His reign also established the tone from which Muhammad bin Tughlaq later departed.

First, the local OCR stresses Ghiyasuddin's **moderation**: taxation should sustain agriculture and crafts rather than destroy them. This is important because Topic 05 later contrasts it with Muhammad's harder and more uniform fiscal push in the doab.

Second, Ghiyasuddin renewed imperial assertion. Warangal was re-secured through Ulugh Khan and Bengal was campaigned against successfully. Thus Muhammad did not inherit a broken shell; he inherited an energised but still consolidating state.

Third, Tughlaqabad and Ghiyasuddin's tomb announced a new dynastic style - fortified, austere and authority-centred.

Finally, his death after the Bengal return is itself a lesson in source criticism: pavilion collapse is secure, conspiracy certainty is not.

Hence Ghiyasuddin's brief reign is the hinge between Khalji breakdown and the larger Tughlaq experiment in empire.

Why this earns marks: It shows transition, policy tone, imperial handoff and source criticism in one compact structure.

Original Mains 02 - 10 marks - 150 words

Question: Why should the Daulatabad and token-currency measures of Muhammad bin Tughlaq be analysed as problems of administrative credibility rather than as mere eccentricity?

Model answer:

Both Daulatabad and token currency had intelligible aims, but both required a level of **credible compliance** that the Sultanate could not sustain.

Daulatabad was not random whim. Devagiri was already a strategic Deccan base, and a second-capital model could have improved supervision over the south. The policy failed because migration was coercive, distance was punishing, and the southern direct-rule project itself weakened. The centre could not make the burden appear legitimate for long enough.

Token currency likewise was not absurd in conception. Fiduciary money had wider precedents. The failure came because the state could not monopolise authentication; unofficial imitation spread and trust collapsed.

In both cases, the question is not whether the ruler "had an idea," but whether roads, local cooperation, mint control, public trust and follow-through existed. They did not exist in sufficient strength.

Therefore, these measures are best treated as credibility failures of a high-ambition state, not as evidence of random madness.

Why this earns marks: It links two famous policies through one analytical thread - credibility - and moves beyond stock storytelling.

Original Mains 03 - 15 marks - 250 words

Question: Examine how the doab crisis, Diwan-i-Amir-i-Kohi and the Khurasan/Qarachil episodes reveal the limits of Muhammad bin Tughlaq's state capacity.

Model answer:

Muhammad bin Tughlaq's reign reveals a ruler trying to make a vast empire fiscally legible and strategically secure. The doab crisis, Diwan-i-Amir-i-Kohi and the Khurasan/Qarachil episodes show that his **objectives were often rational, but his instruments were too brittle**.

In the **doab**, the state relied on standard yield and official prices rather than actual local conditions. Under famine-like stress and harsh collection, the effective burden became explosive. This shows an information problem: the centre could demand, but it could not adapt quickly enough to ecological and local realities.

The **Diwan-i-Amir-i-Kohi** shows another limit. The objective - extend cultivation and improve crops through loans - was developmental. Yet honest local supervision, agronomic knowledge and recovery discipline were weak. Funds were misused, and the measure failed administratively.

The **Khurasan project** and **Qarachil expedition** display the military side of the same problem. A strategic forward move toward the north-west required sustainable finance and dependable purpose; a mountain campaign required terrain-sensitive logistics. Neither requirement was adequately met.

Across all three cases, the pattern is clear: the Sultanate could imagine larger scales of extraction, improvement and frontier control than it could enforce credibly.

Thus Muhammad's failure was not absence of thought, but a mismatch between imperial ambition and operational capacity.

Why this earns marks: It answers through a common concept - state capacity - and integrates fiscal, developmental and military evidence.

Original Mains 04 - 15 marks - 250 words

Question: Discuss Firuz Shah Tughlaq's public works and benevolence. To what extent did they strengthen, and to what extent did they soften, the Delhi Sultanate?

Model answer:

Firuz Shah strengthened the Sultanate in the short run by reorienting rule toward **public works, agrarian recovery and elite reassurance**, but he softened key institutions whose weakness became visible after his death.

On the strengthening side, Firuz built canals from the Sutlej and Yamuna systems into the Haryana-Delhi tract, encouraged new cultivation, founded or renewed towns such as Firozabad and Hissar-Firuz, repaired monuments, built hospitals and organised charity. These measures improved the core north-Indian zone economically and ideologically. They helped present the state as beneficent rather than merely punitive.

Yet the same reign softened the Sultanate structurally. Nobles gained heredity in office and iqta. Soldiers increasingly held revenue assignments and service became hereditary. Audit terror receded, but so did discipline. The slave corps, meant as a pool of dependent manpower, became another political bloc.

Religious legitimacy also came at a cost. Firuz's sharper orthodoxy, separate jizya and temple-related coercion pleased sections of the ulema but narrowed the ideological coalition of rule.

Therefore, Firuz strengthened the **core landscape and immediate legitimacy** of the Sultanate, but softened the **central coercive and administrative edge** on which long-run durability depended.

Why this earns marks: It gives a balanced verdict and measures success in two time-scales - immediate and long-term.

Original Mains 05 - 20 marks - 250 words

Question: Compare Muhammad bin Tughlaq and Firuz Shah Tughlaq in terms of ambition, fiscal strategy, elite management and durability of rule.

Model answer:

Muhammad bin Tughlaq and Firuz Shah Tughlaq represent two sharply different responses to the same Delhi-Sultanate problem: how to hold together a large and diverse empire from a northern core.

In **ambition**, Muhammad was maximalist. He tried to retain the Deccan under direct rule, experiment with a second capital, push fiscal extraction in the doab, attempt fiduciary coinage and contemplate forward frontier strategy. Firuz was minimalist by comparison: he accepted the loss of the south, did not seek full reconquest and concentrated on a governable northern heartland.

In **fiscal strategy**, Muhammad relied on heavy assessment, standardisation and a bold monetary measure that required strong credibility. Firuz relied more on softer collection, irrigation-led expansion, cesses-remission claims and benefits that often flowed through hereditary office-holders.

In **elite management**, Muhammad widened recruitment, bringing in foreigners and "new men," but this reduced aristocratic cohesion and fed chronicler resentment. Firuz preferred conciliation: high salaries, heredity in office and reduced audit pressure. This bought peace but encouraged oligarchic closure.

In **durability**, Muhammad's innovations collapsed quickly when trust, climate and compliance failed. Firuz's peace lasted longer, but the institutions underneath became softer: the army lost sharpness, nobles entrenched themselves, and succession became fragile.

Thus Muhammad over-strained the Sultanate's capacity, while Firuz undercut its central edge. One failed through overreach; the other through over-accommodation.

Why this earns marks: It compares ruler to ruler across four specified dimensions and gives a nuanced final contrast instead of a moral ranking.

Original Mains 06 - 20 marks - 250 words

Question: Historiography often contrasts Muhammad bin Tughlaq as a "visionary failure" and Firuz Shah as a "welfare ruler." Critically examine both labels.

Model answer:

Both labels contain a fragment of truth but become misleading when used without institutional analysis.

Muhammad bin Tughlaq can be called **visionary** only in the limited sense that several of his policies had rational and far-reaching objectives: a more central imperial capital pattern, wider monetary circulation, developmental cultivation and a forward strategic frontier. But "failure" must be explained, not moralised. The failure lay in weak compliance mechanisms - coercive migration without durable consent, token currency without mint control, agrarian development without honest local supervision and strategic projects without stable logistics. The label is useful only if converted into a **state-capacity diagnosis**.

Firuz Shah can be called a **welfare ruler** because he invested in canals, hospitals, marriage assistance, charity, gardens, repairs and urban works. Yet the label becomes romantic if it hides selectivity, political utility and exclusion. Much benevolence favoured core-region and respectable beneficiaries, while the same reign deepened heredity in office, empowered the slave corps, tightened juristic hierarchy and made jizya a sharper marker.

Therefore, neither label should be discarded entirely, but both must be disciplined. Muhammad was not a mad eccentric; Firuz was not a universally benevolent developmental king. Each ruler's reputation becomes historically meaningful only when linked to **who benefited, who obeyed, what instrument was used and what endured**.

Why this earns marks: It turns two familiar labels into a critical historiography answer anchored in evidence and qualification.

Final consolidated register notes

01. Scope and framing

- Topic 05 runs from **1320 to 1388**, from Ghiyasuddin's takeover to Firuz's death and the succession crisis.
- Use **source criticism + state capacity + owner boundaries**, not moral caricatures.
- Topic 04 owns Khalji institutions in depth; Topic 06 owns Timur/Sayyids/Lodis; Topic 09 owns Vijayanagara-Bahmani in depth; Topic 11 owns full architecture survey.

02. Ghiyasuddin transition

- Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq defeated Khusrau Khan in 1320 and restored dynastic order.
- Key tone = **moderation**, agrarian protection, restoration of noble households and renewed campaigning.
- Tughlaqabad and Ghiyasuddin's tomb announce a fortified-austere dynastic style.
- Death after Bengal return = secure pavilion collapse, disputed conspiracy, legendary curse layer.

03. Muhammad's profile and inherited pressures

- Learned ruler: religion, philosophy, mathematics, medicine, Persian/Hindi poetry.
- Associated with Sufis, yogis and Jain scholars; Barani's "rationalist" phrase matters.
- Inherited widest directly ruled Delhi empire yet attempted: north core + Gujarat + Malwa + Deccan + Warangal + far south.
- Core problem = **scale without reliable compliance**.

04. Muhammad's key experiments

- Daulatabad = **second-capital logic**, not total-empty Delhi story.
- Token currency = **copper/brass fiduciary coinage**, not paper currency.
- Doab = standard yield + official prices + hard collection + famine = agrarian rebellion.
- Diwan-i-Amir-i-Kohi = agrarian extension and loans; objective rational, execution weak.
- Khurasan and Qarachil must be kept separate.

05. Rebellion and fragmentation

- Bengal, Mabar, Warangal, Gujarat, Sindh and others reveal cumulative overstretch.
- Plague and distance matter; so do elite opportunism and coercive fatigue.
- Vijayanagara and Bahmani emerge in this context, but their full story belongs elsewhere.
- Best phrase = **direct rule gave way to contested sovereignty**.

06. Muhammad's archive and religious politics

- Barani = indispensable but later, aristocratic, rhetorical and hostile to "low-born" rise.
- Isami = alternative Deccan-facing narrative with displacement bias.
- Ibn Battuta = strong for court, roads, punishments, gifts and urban experience; limited for village-wide statistics.
- Muhammad sought caliphal legitimacy after ulema hostility but remained a ruler of mixed openness and harsh coercion.

07. Firuz's accession and elite bargain

- Firuz came to power in 1351 after the Sindh crisis, with the south already lost.
- Strategy = **appease nobles + soldiers + theologians**, govern a smaller core.
- No major southern reconquest; Bengal campaigns failed; Jainagar/Nagarkot/Thatta gave mixed results.
- Caliphal investiture under Firuz = symbolic legitimacy, not real delegated sovereignty.

08. Firuz's institutions and public works

- Hereditary offices and iqtas brought short-term calm, long-term oligarchic weakness.
- Army service also tended toward heredity; *wajh* village assignments and relaxed branding weakened discipline.

- Canals, towns, gardens, dams, hospitals and repairs mattered, especially in the north-Indian core.
- *haqq-i-sharb* = irrigation-related levy on canal beneficiaries.

09. Firuz's limits: slaves, orthodoxy and succession

- Diwan-i-Bandagan = slave labour/service/political dependence, not welfare.
- Benevolence was real but selective; not a modern welfare state.
- Separate jizya, denial of Brahman exemption, temple-related coercion and sectarian action show sharper orthodoxy.
- Succession after 1388 was weakened by princes, nobles and slave-corp interventions.

10. Comparative verdict and PYQ routes

- Muhammad = innovation + direct control + weak compliance.
- Firuz = conciliation + development + weak long-run central discipline.
- Historical significance = widest Delhi reach, clearest over-stretch, Deccan political consequences, canal/public-works core, pre-Timur weakening.
- PYQ routes used here: 2021 Prelims chronology (direct), 2022 Mongol chronology (adjacent), 2020 Persian sources (adjacent), 2023 Sultanate technology (adjacent).